NO. 135 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 17 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



THE WATCH THAT MADE THE BRAND, BROUGHT BACK AT FORTY-TWO MILLIMETRES (P10)

THE GOOD LIFE

MB&F shrank its 2011 Legacy Machine to 42mm and priced it at CHF 82,000

THE RABBIT HOLE

A Belgian hen made €1.6m; Britain's pigeon union has lost 14 per cent of its members

THE TRAVEL DESK

Mt Cook takes eight times Tekapo's rain, and the Hooker bridge is new

Source: SJX Watches. The MB&F LM1 EVO in grade-5 titanium, photographed on announcement, 13 October 2026. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 135

Contents

p3 The World — Bulgaria opens a war-crimes file and names nobody
p4 The World — Alberta votes on Monday; 66–34 to stay
p5 Singapore — seven companies named, twelve years on
p6 The Atelier — the screw pivot, and the badge that does nothing
p7 Technology — TSMC beat guidance and the shares fell
p8 The Home Lab — 816 billion parameters across four Macs
p9 The Kit — Singapore is in the launch wave for once
p10 The Good Life — the Legacy Machine comes back at 42mm
p11 Screen & Sound — 84 from seventeen critics, and one C-plus
p12–13 The Family Desk — 21,797 twins; four bans in a week
p14 The Macro Desk — the long end rallied into the worst print
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — pigeon racing, and a €1.6m hen
p18 Fitness — the step target comes down to seven thousand
p19–22 The Travel Desk — Christchurch non-stop; Aoraki and the Catlins
p23–24 The Diary — Ghibli at S$39; Petra opens on the 24th
p25–27 The Long Read — Korea's 33-square-metre loophole
THE SPINE: WHAT COMES BACK — a bird over six hundred miles, a bridge over the Hooker, an Act off the shelf after twelve years, and thirty-nine of our own calls, marked.

FROM THE DESK

"A man should never be ashamed to own he has been in the wrong, which is but saying, in other words, that he is wiser to-day than he was yesterday."

Alexander Pope, *Thoughts on Various Subjects*, **1727**[1]

Pope put it as a boast rather than a confession, which is the useful trick. The Scoreboard below marks thirty-nine calls whose check-by dates have passed. Four issues said a central bank would tighten; it held.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.74%	▼ 6bp wk
US 10-year[2]	5.09%	▼ 15bp wk
VWRA	$191.68	▼ 0.94% wk
Global agg	$5.78	▲ 0.87% wk
DXY	101.78	▼ 0.27%
USD/SGD	1.2796	▼ 0.14%
Brent	$109.66	▲ 3.53%
Gold, spot	$4,165.52	▼ 0.13%
Bitcoin	$81,585	▼ 0.91%

The Straits Times Index closed 5,415.53, up 0.22% (p14). Weekly moves shown only where a daily history could be read. Not advice.[2]

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY

Thirty-nine calls came due. Twenty landed, thirteen missed, four are pushes and two were never gradeable. Misses first.[3]

One statement felled four issues. Nos. 117, 129, 130 and 132 all said the Monetary Authority would tighten on 14 October. It held slope, width and centre; No. 130 even named the quantum, **25bp**. Ten of ten analysts in the Reuters poll were wrong with us, which is context, not a defence.

The most embarrassing, by 29 points. No. 118: Singapore's 24-hour index "does not reach 200 in any region before 31 October". Central reached **229** on the 16th.

SOURCES 1 Pope's *Thoughts on Various Subjects*, first printed in 1727 in the Swift–Pope *Miscellanies*. 2 Levels at Friday's close, each sourced on p14; Treasury yields from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve. **Weekly moves are printed only for the instruments whose daily history this desk could read: the usual history source reset every connection this build.** 3 Every claim in this magazine's own predictions ledger whose check-by date had passed was graded against a figure read where it is published: a central bank's own policy statement and its past-decisions table; a foundry's two filings with the Securities and Exchange Commission; an environment agency's machine feed queried by date; a think tank's own haze outlook release; two box-office databases agreeing to the dollar; a chipmaker's 8-K; a retailer's published price; an aviation authority's casualty statement and a schedule-data service; and a race promoter's own post-event release. **Two rows could not be settled and are not scored. Where a sell-out was announced only after the event and without a category, this column records a push rather than a win.**

THE WORLD · THE BLACK SEA

Sofia opens a war-crimes case over the Chelsea 3 and names no suspect

Sofia's military prosecutors moved on 16 October, three days after the Chelsea 3 was hit inside Bulgaria's own economic zone. Seven ships struck this month; two seafarers dead, twenty-five missing.

The Sofia Military District Prosecution Office opened pre-trial proceedings on **Friday 16 October** into the drone attack on the Malta-flagged cargo ship **Chelsea 3**, struck on the 13th sixteen miles off Byala, inside Bulgaria's exclusive economic zone. The file alleges an order "to kill civilians" and destruction of property on a large scale, under Article 412 of the criminal code. No suspect is named, because Bulgaria has not said who it believes fired.[1]

What the file will examine is by now a pattern: the Associated Press counts **at least seven cargo vessels hit this month** off Romania and Bulgaria, both NATO members, with two seafarers dead and at least twenty-five missing.[2] The **HS Dignity**, bound from Algeria for Brăila, sank east of Krapets the same day — five men out, eleven gone.[3] Two days later the tanker **Wine Trader** burned off Sulina: Romania's Naval Authority counted twelve aboard, four safe and eight missing; later copy settled on five and seven.[4]

Sofia's answer runs on two tracks and only one is legal. Defence Minister **Dimitar Stoyanov** confirmed on the 16th that Bulgaria has asked NATO's secretary general and SACEUR for combat aircraft and anti-drone systems: "We are awaiting their decision." Thirty-two allied ambassadors take it up next week.[5] The European Council, the same day, demanded "the immediate restoration of safe passage for all civilian shipping."[6]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Told through officials, Brussels carrying the argument: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's *"The Black Sea has become another front of escalation of the Russian war in Ukraine."*[8]

VARNA — MARITIME.BG

The littoral reading, and the harder one. Inside twelve miles is sovereign territory, so a formal finding of a deliberate foreign strike is in law an armed attack on a NATO member — which is why, the paper argues, both capitals prefer long investigations to the phrase *"act of war."*[9]

5m

TONNES OF BULGARIAN WHEAT WAITING TO EXPORT, AS SHIPS BEGIN REFUSING THE PORTS THAT WOULD LOAD IT[10]

THE CHATTER · THE FIRST INDUSTRY TO SAY IT

Iliya Prodanov, chairman of Bulgaria's grain producers' association, told state broadcaster BNT on the 16th: **"we now have ships that have refused to come to Bulgarian ports."** Nor is the trade press running a one-sided file: the same week it reported a tanker hit *by Ukraine* aground off Istanbul.[10][11]

THE SCEPTIC · AN ATTACK NOBODY MUST ANSWER

Romanian analyst **Radu Tudor** put the uncomfortable question to the AP: it is arguable whether a strike in an economic zone triggers collective defence, and so far it plainly has not. He calls NATO **"too slow"** here. Underwriters are blunter. War risk is quoted at **0.6 to 1 per cent** of hull value against 0.2 to 0.5 a week earlier, says Gennadiy Ivanov of BPG Shipping — and some owners, he adds, now run inside the twelve-mile belt with **no war-risk cover at all**. What would settle attribution is forensics, and Romania can strip a hull that reaches port where Bulgaria cannot.[2][7][9]

SOURCES 1 Bulgaria's national news agency, 16 October 2026, read at source, for the proceedings, the referral, the investigator and the two complainant bodies — Bulgarian Lawyers for Human Rights and the Bulgarian Helsinki Committee; the statute citation (Article 412, letters "a" and "e") from a Varna maritime trade paper the same evening. 2 The Associated Press, 16 October, read at source, for the seven-vessel count, the casualty totals and the analyst. 3 A French agency file of 13 October, read at source, for both vessels' flags, routes, positions and crew. 4 **Romania's Naval Authority's own release of 15 October, downloaded as a PDF and read in Romanian**, for the position, the fire and the first tally of four safe and eight missing; five-and-seven is later agency copy. **This desk prints both rather than choosing.** 5 Reuters, 16 October, read at source in syndication. A Bulgarian report that the request also covers missile systems **could not be read — that page returned a rate-limit error — and is not printed.** 6 European Council conclusions of 16 October, **quoted via Bulgaria's national agency because the Council's own press page refused this desk with a 403.** 7 A Turkish business daily's 14 October exclusive, read at source, for the premium quotes, the twelve-mile behaviour and the Joint War Committee's 16 September widening. 8 Al Jazeera, 13 October, read at source. 9 A Varna maritime trade paper, 16 October, read at source, for the territorial-sea argument and the forensics asymmetry. 10 Bulgaria's state broadcaster via that trade paper, 16 October, for the grain chairman and the tonnage. 11 The same trade paper, 15 October. **Reddit refused this desk for a third consecutive issue, and a Hacker News search found no thread on the merchant attacks in the window — so no forum sentiment is reported here.**

THE WORLD · ALBERTA

Alberta votes Monday on starting the legal road out of Canada

Question ten was written by Danielle Smith's government and is non-binding by its own order in council. Angus Reid put remain ahead 66 to 34 on 16 October.

Albertans vote on **Monday 19 October** on ten referendum questions, the last of which asks them to choose between remaining a province of Canada and having the provincial government begin the legal process for a binding vote on separation. Advance polls ran from the 13th. Question ten was added by **Order in Council 160/2026** of 28 May, which states on its face that the results "are not to be binding".[1]

The polling has been one-sided and stable. The Angus Reid Institute, publishing on **16 October**, found **66 per cent** for remaining against 34 for beginning the process; Leger had 70–22 in early October, Ipsos 70–20 in September. Angus Reid consistently returns the highest leave share of any pollster, worth knowing before anyone calls 34 a surge. Three of its findings matter more than the headline: **78 per cent** had decided before the campaign began, **62 per cent** think the separatist movement will not end whatever Monday says, and among leave voters **60 per cent** call their motive sending Ottawa a message while only 37 want separation.[2]

This ballot exists because a court stopped the first one. On **13 May** the Court of King's Bench quashed Elections Alberta's approval of a citizen-initiated separation petition, finding the province owed a duty to consult Indigenous peoples and had not met it. The province appealed; Smith's government then wrote its own non-binding question. The Otipemisiwak Métis Government published voting guidance on the 13th: Métis rights are recognised under section 35 and "are not rights that the Province of Alberta simply granted", and Indigenous governments "cannot be treated as an afterthought".[3]

37%

OF LEAVE VOTERS WHO SAY THEY ACTUALLY WANT SEPARATION. THE OTHER 63 PER CENT ARE USING THE BALLOT AS A LETTER TO OTTAWA[2]

ALSO THIS WEEK

The order to throttle Ukraine's Starshield came from inside the White House. Reuters reported on 15 October that two US officials and a Western official traced the instruction to slow SpaceX's military service for Ukraine to the White House; none would name who gave it. A senior official said "No such request was ever made by the president." A Ukrainian defence source says military receivers now work in motion only up to **160km/h**, degrading the interceptor drones Ukraine flies against Shaheds. Elon Musk wrote that because the government owns Starshield, its limits are set by the military or the president. No. 134 held open the explanation the Pentagon had not given. This is it — and **it rests on one wire and three anonymous officials.**[4]

THE CHATTER · WHO ACTUALLY CAMPAIGNED

Mark Carney held two "Forever Canadian" rallies this week, in Calgary and Edmonton, after a Thanksgiving video shot at his old Edmonton high school: **"This referendum comes at the worst possible time… Some beyond our borders are trying to divide us so they can have us."** On the 15th he told a Calgary rally the United States is trying to break Canada.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · BOUGHT, NOT ORGANISED

The Hub, citing a Globe and Mail analysis, argues Ottawa bought the remain side with pipeline approvals and concessions while building almost no ground operation — so 66 per cent may say less about federal persuasion than it looks. **Grant Sprague**, a former Alberta deputy energy minister now at the C.D. Howe Institute, calls the Pacific Link national-interest designation **"closer to a political promise than an approval".**[6]

SOURCES 1 **Elections Alberta's own referendum page, read at source**, for the ten questions, the advance-poll window and Order in Council 160/2026 of 28 May 2026, including the quoted non-binding clause. 2 **The Angus Reid Institute's own release of 16 October 2026, read at source**, for the 66/34 split and the decided, persistence and motive findings, and for its comparative table carrying Leger (2–4 Oct, n=1,001, ±3.1) and Ipsos (18–22 Sep, n=600, ±4.9). **The field dates and sample for the 16 October poll itself sit in a linked PDF this desk did not read, so no margin of error is printed for it.** 3 The Otipemisiwak Métis Government's own statement of 13 October, read at source, for both quoted passages. **The 13 May ruling is reported via secondary accounts, not read in the law reports.** 4 Reuters, 15 October, read at source in syndication. 5 Al Jazeera, 12 October, read at source; the Calgary line via the Associated Press. 6 The Hub, 14 October, read at source, for both named quotations. **Washington Post and CBC refused this desk with 403s; Reddit refused for a third consecutive issue and a Hacker News search found nothing in the window.**

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE ACT

NEA names seven Indonesian companies under the Haze Act, a first in twelve years

The notices went out on 16 October, the day the central 24-hour index peaked at 229. They order firefighting and a plan of action — they are not prosecutions, and NEA set no deadline.

The National Environment Agency issued Preventive Measure Notices under the **Transboundary Haze Pollution Act** on **Friday 16 October** to seven Indonesian concession-holders: PT Bumi Andalas Permai, PT Bumi Mekar Hijau, PT Paramitra Mulia Langgeng, PT Sumatera Alam Anugerah, PT SBA Wood Industries, PT Hutan Lestari Raya and PT Bangkanesia. Each is directed to deploy firefighting personnel to land it owns or occupies, to stop or not begin burning there, and to submit a plan of action to NEA.[1]

This is the Act's first use since it passed in 2014, and the limits matter as much as the names. These are **preventive** notices, not charges: NEA's release sets **no deadline**, cites **no section**, names **no penalty** and does not mention the fires of 8–9 October, saying only that the agency "remains committed to taking enforcement action against errant companies" found responsible. No. 134 reported that in twelve years the Act had produced nothing; on its own terms that still holds. One rung is lit, not the ladder. Grace Fu said the agency would investigate all companies found responsible, and Prime Minister Lawrence Wong said action would follow "where warranted."[17]

It came on the worst day of the episode. NEA's own readings put the **central region's 24-hour PSI at 229** between three and four on Friday afternoon, with west and east at 205 — three regions Very Unhealthy at once, the highest of 2026. By five on Saturday morning central had eased to **194**, west 185, east 179, south 164, north 145.[2] PM2.5 is the binding pollutant in every region. NEA forecasts **150 to 230** for Saturday and expects weakening winds from the 18th to carry less Kalimantan smoke.[3]

7

COMPANIES NAMED, AGAINST ZERO IN THE ACT'S FIRST TWELVE YEARS. ALSO ZERO: DEADLINES, SECTIONS CITED, PENALTIES STATED[1]

WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE WEEKEND

No school closures. MOE shuts schools on a next-day forecast above 300, and the forecast is 150–230. Education Minister Desmond Lee said on the 16th that O-Level papers may be rescheduled if the air turns hazardous. ActiveSG closed outdoor and non-air-conditioned facilities in the east and central on the 15th; by Friday afternoon it covered **all** sport centres.[4]

Masks, and what they cost. N95s are going out through community clubs and vending machines; MOH confirms KN95, FFP2 and KF94 are equivalent. Under the Haze Subsidy Scheme, Pioneer and Merdeka seniors pay at most **S$5**, other eligible groups **S$10**.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE SHOPS ARE SELLING

The clearest measure of a household's week is a retailer's order book. Gain City's air-purifier sales rose **76 per cent** in September over August, Courts reported more than a fourfold rise over three to four weeks, Audio House doubled. Buyers who used to ask the price now ask about **CADR**. And a detail no index captures: rainwater collected in pails this week came up blackish.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · A NOTICE IS NOT A FINE

Read coldly, Friday's release is the cheapest instrument the Act contains. A Preventive Measure Notice asks a company to put out a fire it is already obliged to put out; the Act's teeth — civil liability, criminal penalty — need causation proved across a border, which is why twelve years produced nothing. Note too what the notices did *not* accompany: NEA's haze advisory the same day mentions neither the Act nor Indonesia. What would make this a turning point is one named prosecution, or a published deadline.[17]

SOURCES 1 **The National Environment Agency's own media release of 16 October 2026, read at source**, for all seven company names in its order and the three directions each notice carries. **The absence of a deadline, a cited section, a stated penalty and any reference to the 8–9 October fires are properties of the release itself.** 2 **NEA's machine-readable feed, queried directly** — the 17 October 05:00 reading, for all five regional values and the sub-indices that make PM2.5 binding; the 16 October maxima, central 229 at 15:00–16:00, from the same feed queried for that date. 3 NEA's Haze Situation Update of 16 October, read at source, for the 8pm ranges, the verbatim 150–230 forecast, the Kalimantan attribution and the wind outlook. NEA publishes no hotspot count, noting cloud cover prevented determining the full extent. 4 A Singapore news site, 16 October, for the education minister's remarks and both SportSG steps; **his words are paraphrased, not quoted, because this desk did not reach a transcript.** 5 NEA's advisory of 14 October and a Singapore daily of the 16th. **A reported count of 113 community clubs and 37 vending machines is single-sourced and is not printed.** 6 A Singapore news site, 10 October, citing a Chinese-language daily, read at source. **Larger figures from a paywalled wire report were not read at source and are not printed.** 7 Reported ministerial remarks of 16 October via two outlets. **Indonesia's reported approval of foreign assistance is single-sourced and is held.**

THE ATELIER · SCISSORS & SHEARS

Ernest Wright's Sheffield putters still set shears by hand; Gingher is now Fiskars

Two blades touch at one travelling point, and a screw pivot decides whether a pair can ever be re-trued. Ernest Wright's quality entry is £99; above about £150 you buy size and scarcity, not cutting.

A good pair of scissors does not have flat blades, and the edges do not meet along a line. Each blade is given a slight inward curvature — the **set** — so that under tension the two edges touch at exactly one point, which travels from the bolt to the tips as you close. Behind the pivot they bear on each other at the **ride** — the trade and the patent literature call it the half-moon. That moving point is what shears cloth, and everything else follows from it.[1]

Which is why the first thing to look at is the **pivot**. A screw means the pair comes apart, so the faces can be stoned, the ride re-trued and the tension re-set; a rivet means none of that, whatever the steel. The second is the section.[2]

Japan reaches the same place by another route. A hand-forged shear from Ono or Sakai is usually **two metals forge-welded** — a hard high-carbon steel on a soft iron body, the logic of a single-bevel knife. At Sasuke in Sakai a knife takes a day and a pair of scissors about four. The grades are Yasugi "paper" steels: **Shirogami**, pure plain carbon, finest edge and fastest to rust; **Aogami**, the same with chromium and tungsten added.[3]

WHAT YOU ARE PAYING FOR

TIER	PAIR	PRICE
Sweet spot, Sheffield	Ernest Wright 8.25″	£99
Sweet spot, Japan	Yoshioka, Shirogami No.2	¥21,168
Salon grail	Joewell Coaxis CAX-580	¥187,000

Read at each maker's or stockist's own page, 16 October 2026. The quality entry is a Higashi Fuji 240mm at A$59; the 13-inch Heritage, at £600, is waitlist-only.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE TRADE ON ITSELF

The sharpeners are the honest witnesses. Steve Bottorff, who teaches professional sharpening, sets tension so the blades **"close freely for half of the blade length, but have tension in the final half"**. On salon shears his forum is discouraging: the micro-serrations **"trap hair shafts so they cannot roll as they are cut"**, and grinding them off ruins the shear. Never hand one to a knife sharpener.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE BADGE DOES NOTHING

Gingher was a 1947 forging house; it is now a Fiskars Group product made in Italy, and gingher.com redirects to an Amazon storefront. **"Solingen"** is a protected designation, but the ordinance governs *where* the stages happen — Solingen or Haan — not whether anything was hot-forged, and Kretzer's own site says its ECO line is **"produced in close cooperation with international partners"**. Note too what the grail makers will not publish: Joewell lists about 150 models with weights to **half a gram** and **no steel grade and no hardness at all**.[6][7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Nail clippers & nippers — Suwada and Seki Edge against the chemist counter.

Safety razors & blades — Merkur, Feather, and who really makes the blades.

Leather watch straps — who stitches the strap in the famous box.

SOURCES 1 A professional sharpener's forum posts, 2015, read at source, for the set, the ride line and the tension rule; "ride" and "half-moon" confirmed in two US scissor patents. 2 **Ernest Wright's own product pages, read at source 16 October 2026**, for C50 and C60, "hot drop forged", the 1,500g Heritage and the batch language. 3 Maker and retailer pages for Tajika, Yoshioka and Okatsune, read at source, for "laminated blades", Shirogami and Aogami. **The Sasuke four-days-a-pair account reached us through a search index only: a menswear journal, an embassy page and a knife forum all refused us with 403s.** 4 Each maker's or stockist's own page, 16 October. **Tajika's site carries no shop, price or lead time; Shozaburo's returned 503, so no price is printed for it.** 5 The same sharpening forum, April–June 2015. 6 A 2005 Fiskars release and gingher.com's live redirect; Kretzer's own line descriptions; **Joewell's own 150-model price table — the absence of any steel grade or hardness is a property of that table**. The Solingen ordinance reached us via the search index of two official pages that refused a direct read. 7 A Singapore craft-retail guide and a local sharpening specialist's own site. **Reddit refused this desk again, so no r/BuyItForLife sentiment is reported.**

TECHNOLOGY · TSMC

Shares in TSMC fell 3.4 per cent on a $920m beat

Revenue was US$46.72bn against a guided US$44.6–45.8bn; C.C. Wei lifted 2026 growth to "around 44" per cent. Gross margin slipped 1.3 points, and capex is held, not raised.

Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company reported third-quarter results in Hsinchu on **Wednesday 15 October**: revenue of **NT$1,494.24bn, or US$46.72bn**, up 50.9 per cent on the year and 17.6 per cent on the quarter, against its own July guidance of **US$44.6bn to US$45.8bn**. Net income was NT$763.06bn, up 68.7 per cent; gross margin **66.4 per cent**. Nodes at 7nm and below made **79 per cent** of wafer revenue, with 2nm already at 8 per cent and 3nm at 33.[1]

Chief executive **C.C. Wei** raised full-year dollar revenue growth to **"around 44" per cent** from July's "slightly more than 40", and said of accelerator demand that **"the demand is higher than the supply, and we are working very hard to narrow the gap."** On the growth rate he has guided for AI accelerators through 2029: **"We did not see any sign of slowdown."** Fourth-quarter guidance is US$52.3–54.3bn, and N2 capacity more than doubles in 2027.[12]

And the stock closed down **3.4 per cent at $430**, falling another two per cent after hours. Three numbers explain it better than any note. Gross margin fell **1.3 points** from 67.7, which management attributed mainly to the 2nm ramp and expects to continue into the fourth quarter. Overseas-fab dilution, about two points now, widens to **three or four**. And chief financial officer **Wendell Huang reiterated rather than raised** 2026 capital spending at US$60–64bn, while saying 2026–28 capex will be "even more significantly higher than the past three years". Wei called the company "prudent about 2027".[23]

79%

OF WAFER REVENUE FROM 7NM AND BELOW. TWO-NANOMETRE IS ALREADY A TWELFTH OF IT, ONE QUARTER AFTER RAMP[1]

THE SAME WEEK

China put its own AI models under export control, effective the day it announced them. On 16 October the commerce and science ministries issued **Announcement No. 48**, opening comment on a revised technology-export catalogue and imposing an immediate registration regime on the technologies in its annex — including deals already under way. The draft adds **40 technologies, 14 prohibited and 26 restricted, 23 of them AI**: 2.5D and 3D chip design, cluster interconnect and scheduling, agent planning and tool use. The carve-out is the story for anyone downloading weights: technologies already public through **open-source release or academic publication are outside scope**, and open-source releases of restricted AI technology get automatic licensing — "register and export", in the spokesman's phrase. Comment closes 15 November.[4]

Still on the shelf: Arm and Qualcomm. Neither of Judge Maryellen Noreika's reserved rulings — whether the licence breach lets Qualcomm suspend royalties for up to five years, and whether Arm negotiated in good faith — had landed by the 17th. The $2 verdict of 13 October stands.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE ANALYSTS ASKED

The call is the community read. **Laura Chen of Citi** pressed management on overbuilding and power constraints; the answer was that TSMC triangulates top-down and bottom-up forecasts and **checks US data-centre build-outs directly**. J.P. Morgan, TD Cowen, Morgan Stanley, UBS and BofA asked about pricing, High-NA EUV timing, insourcing and dilution. The phrase "AI bubble" was never put to them. Price targets went up, not down: Needham to $560, Barclays to $670.[23]

THE SCEPTIC · A DRAFT THAT POLICES NOTHING YET

On Beijing's controls, the sceptical case is that only the paperwork is real. The catalogue is still a **draft open for comment**; what is in force is a registration formality the ministry itself pairs with automatic licensing for open source. Nothing a home-lab operator downloads today changes.[4]

SOURCES 1 **TSMC's own Form 6-K for the third quarter of 2026, filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission and read at source**, for every revenue, margin, income and node figure and for the fourth-quarter guidance; its second-quarter 6-K, also read at source, for the US$44.6–45.8bn range the print beat. **The release states the quarter's figures have not been approved by the board.** 2 Two independent full transcripts of the 15 October earnings call, read at source, for the quoted remarks, the capex language, the node and fab timings and the named analyst questions. 3 A market-news transcript service, read at source, for the close, the after-hours move and the margin attribution; the raised price targets are aggregator write-ups of sell-side notes rather than the notes themselves, and are flagged as such. 4 **The Ministry of Commerce's Announcement No. 48 of 2026, in Chinese, read at source**, for the registration clause and the date, and the ministry spokesman's own question-and-answer page for the scope and the open-source position; the 14-and-26 split and the sector counts via state media and an independent legal analysis that itemises the annex. **Thresholds widely reported as two trillion parameters and 14nm appear nowhere in the announcement body this desk read, and are not printed.** 5 Two trade reports of the Delaware verdict, read at source. **Reddit refused this desk again; the GitHub API returned 403, so release and pull-request pages were read as web pages.**

THE HOME LAB · MUSE SPARK OPEN

Apple ran Meta's 816B model across four Mac Studios at 36.73 tokens a second

Apple Machine Learning Research published the numbers on 15 October, over Thunderbolt 5 RDMA. One commenter priced the rig at thirty thousand dollars; another runs DeepSeek on one machine at forty-five.

Apple Machine Learning Research published measured multi-machine inference figures on **Thursday 15 October**, running **Meta's Muse Spark Open** — 816 billion parameters total, 42 billion active — over **Thunderbolt 5 RDMA**, a driver that arrived in macOS 26.2, using the jaccl backend in MLX. The model needs over 1.6TB in BF16 and about 493GB at NVFP4, so it does not fit one machine. Decode on two M5 Ultra Mac Studios ran **15.74 tokens a second** in pipeline parallel, **24.99** in tensor parallel, and **36.73 across four**.[1]

The generational numbers are the useful part for anyone choosing hardware. A single M5 Ultra is up to **4.6× faster on time-to-first-token** and 1.6× on decode than an M3 Ultra, which is the difference between 95.9 seconds and 24.6 to first token on a 128B dense model at 65,536 tokens of context. Two cables beat one: the same four-machine run took about **40.6 seconds against 50.5**. Peak power is roughly 200W on the M3 Ultra and 300W on the M5.[1]

What actually fits a single-operator budget is the quantisation ladder, and it was published the same week. Unsloth's dynamic GGUF builds run from **UD-IQ1_S at 176GB** through UD-IQ2_XXS at 226GB and UD-Q2_K_XL at 311GB to **UD-Q4_K_XL at 506GB**; it recommends starting at IQ2_XXS, calls **IQ2_S the practical minimum for agentic work**, and says anything below that is degraded. Note the publishers disagree on the floor: Unsloth says the two-bit build fits **256GB** of combined memory, Meta's own guidance says about **300GB**. Both figures are printed here because neither is independent.[2]

Support landed fast. llama.cpp **pull request 30616**, by ServeurpersoCom, was opened and merged on **15 October** — nine commits, approved by four maintainers — with the text path matching the reference implementation at a cosine similarity of **1.000000000** and the audio tower at 0.999999926. The architecture as implemented is 8,192 residual width, **256 experts of 4,096 with top-8 routing**, a 2,048-token sliding window. No perplexity figures were published in the thread.[3]

176GB

THE SMALLEST UNSLOTH BUILD OF AN 816B MODEL. THE ONE-BIT TIER; IQ2_S, AT 275GB, IS THE FLOOR THE PACKAGER WILL DEFEND[2]

THE CHATTER · HACKER NEWS DOES THE ARITHMETIC

Reddit refused this desk again, so the read is Hacker News, where the Apple paper drew about **229 points and 104 comments** and the model itself **898 points and 463**. The pricing objections came first. **devy** put the recommended setup at **"$28–30K"**; **ryanschaefer**, "This is gonna cost like 50k to run at home"; **isodev**, drily, "Preparing to upsell those very expensive Macs coming later this month, are we." **bahmboo** dissented that twenty to thirty thousand for specialty hardware is affordable. The most useful counter-datum came from **liuliu**: a single **M5 Ultra with 256GB runs DeepSeek at about 45 tokens a second** — which suggests the interesting local configuration is one machine, not four.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE CONTEXT LENGTH

Two hits land. **mrboatshoepants** notes the headline chart uses only an **8,192-token context**, which is "not nearly enough context to be useful these days" — and the paper's own 36-plus figure is at that length, not at the 65,536 its tables elsewhere use. **peri-cl** points out Apple compared Meta's model at four-bit against Qwen at BF16, "sandbagging Qwen". On the model, **bel8** cites Artificial Analysis putting Muse Spark Open at **39, level with DeepSeek V4.1 Flash and below Meta's own closed 1.3 at 45** — so "the most capable US open-weight model" is level with a Chinese open one.[4][5]

SOURCES 1 **Apple Machine Learning Research's own write-up, read at source**, for every decode, time-to-first-token, memory, cable and power figure. The page lists no authors and **does not compare RDMA against Ethernet** — its only interconnect comparison is one cable against two. 2 **Unsloth's own GGUF repository listing and run-locally guide, read at source**, for the full size ladder, the recommended starting tier and the 256GB claim; **Meta's own developer guide, read at source**, for the ~300GB floor. The two disagree and both are printed. 3 **llama.cpp pull request 30616, read at source as a web page because the GitHub API returned 403**, for the merge date, the commit count, the approvals, the cosine-similarity verifications and the architecture. **No perplexity numbers appear in the thread; that gap is the thread's, not ours.** 4 Two Hacker News threads, read at source, for the point and comment counts and every quoted commenter by handle. **User-reported token rates in those threads state no hardware and are not treated as measurements.** 5 **The model card on its publisher's own hub, read at source**, for the licence revenue threshold, the attribution requirement and the Artificial Analysis figure of 39. **Reddit refused this desk for a third consecutive issue, so there is no r/LocalLLaMA read in this edition.**

THE KIT · APPLE HOMEVIEW

Apple priced HomeView at S$399 in Singapore and opened pre-orders on 15 October

It ships here on 13 November, in the launch wave for once. Thread goes unmentioned in the release — and the S$299 Apple TV 4K is the cheaper hub with the radio Apple does name.

Apple announced **HomeView** at its Welcome Home event on **Tuesday 13 October**: a seven-inch square Liquid Retina display and home hub on an aluminium body and stainless hinge over a domed speaker base, with an **A18** chip, auto-brightness from 500 nits down to **0.3**, two full-range drivers in the screen, a down-firing woofer and two force-cancelling passive radiators in the base. It recognises **up to six people**, each with their own home screen. US$299 for both the table-top and wall-mounted models; **S$399 in Singapore, GST included**, limit two each, pre-orders opened at 9am on **Thursday 15 October** and it ships on **13 November**.[1]

Singapore being in the first wave is the news, after a year in which this desk has recorded the opposite three times. It is not sold in the European Union at all, because Siri AI is not available there. What a Matter household should note is an absence: the HomeView release names Matter accessories and says HomeView, HomePod or Apple TV can act as the home hub, but **does not mention Thread** — conspicuous, because the same day's Home Collection release says every device in that line supports it. Siri AI ships in beta; some server-side features carry daily limits, and Apple says expanded access will cost money later.[12]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Apple TV 4K (2026), US$299, ships 13 November. An A19, up to 50 per cent faster CPU and twice the GPU of its predecessor by Apple's own claim, Wi-Fi **and Thread** built in, and it acts as a home hub. The honest line for this reader: at the same price as HomeView, the cheaper hub in the house is now the box, not the screen. Apple does not enumerate the thirty pre-order markets, so **Singapore availability for the box is unconfirmed from the release**; Singapore does appear in the English Siri AI list. Storage tiers are not stated.[3]

The Apple Home Collection has Thread in everything, and nothing for Singapore. Built with LG and Schneider Electric, US prices run from a US$39.95 sensor to a US$399.95 floodlight camera, and the US$349.95 deadbolt is Matter-compatible and supports Aliro. On sale from December — cameras and doorbell in the US, Canada and UK; lock, thermostats and sensors US and Canada only.[2]

Sony's Signature Walkman gets Singapore prices — S$6,999 for the gold one. Announced for Singapore on 16 October: NW-WM1ZM3 at **S$6,999**, NW-WM1AM3 at S$3,599, the slimmer NW-ZX900 at S$2,399, available from November. Pre-order promotion takes S$1,000, S$400 and S$200 off respectively with free IER-M500 monitors.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE HANDS-ON COULD NOT TEST

Raymond Wong of Gizmodo calls it possibly the highest-quality kitchen-counter smart display he has used — and is scrupulous about what he could not check: **"No invited attendees at Apple's 'Welcome Home' event could try out the face or voice recognition,"** and **"I didn't get to listen to the wall-mounted version,"** which uses different speakers. His hardware gripes: the tilt is **manual only**, the rumoured motorised swivel did not appear, the wall-mounted model has no USB-C port on its underside so the cable runs inside the wall, and the 1.5-metre cable "could prove challenging if an outlet is out of reach".[5]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO REVIEWERS, ONE ROOM, OPPOSITE VERDICTS

There are no reviews, because it ships on 13 November. What exists is event hands-on, and on the one thing a speaker is for they disagree flatly: **TechRadar** found the volume in Apple's demo space **"wasn't quite as powerful as I'd hoped"**, while **CNN Underscored** called it "impressively loud" in the same kind of room.[56]

SOURCES 1 **Apple's own newsroom release of 13 October 2026, read at source**, for every specification, the US price and the privacy and Siri AI conditions; **the Apple Singapore store page, read at source**, for S$399, the two-unit limit and the 13 November date. **The S$399 figure is single-sourced — to the seller, but single-sourced: no Singapore outlet had published it.** The 15 October 9am pre-order time is independently corroborated. 2 **Apple's own Home Collection release, read at source**, for every price, the Thread claims, the Matter and Aliro claims and the market list. **Apple does not claim Matter for the cameras.** 3 **Apple's own Apple TV 4K release, read at source.** It does not enumerate its pre-order markets and does not state storage tiers; both gaps are the release's. 4 One regional outlet, 16 October, read at source. **Single-sourced: Sony Singapore's own release was not found and no second Singapore outlet carried the figures, so verify before ordering. No specifications are printed because none were published.** 5 Gizmodo, 13 October, read at source, for both quoted limitations and every hardware gripe. 6 TechRadar and CNN Underscored hands-on pieces, read at source, for the two contradictory loudness verdicts. **Ray-Ban Meta Audio acquired a US shipping peg this week but the Singapore position is unchanged from No. 133, so it is not re-run.**

THE GOOD LIFE · MB&F

MB&F brought back the Legacy Machine at 42mm, priced at CHF 82,000

The LM1 EVO, announced 13 October, puts the 2011 watch that made the brand into the sports case. Titanium is regular production; the rose-gold green dial is thirty-three pieces.

MB&F announced the **LM1 EVO** on **Tuesday 13 October**: the Legacy Machine N°1 of 2011, the watch that established the brand, rebuilt in the sportier EVO case and brought down to **42mm** across and 16.8 thick. **CHF 82,000** in grade-5 titanium and **CHF 102,000** in 18k rose gold, both before tax; in dollars, **$109,000 and $137,000**. The titanium is regular production and the green-dial rose gold is limited to **thirty-three pieces** — which makes the titanium, unusually for this house, the real entry to the collection.[1]

What changed mechanically is more than a case. The hand-wound calibre keeps the floating balance beating at 2.5Hz under the domed crystal and the two fully independent time zones, but the power reserve goes from 45 hours to **60**, a third more; the up-and-down indicator becomes a gauge; and the overcoil hairspring is replaced by **opposed Straumann hairsprings**. Water resistance is **80 metres** on twin screw-down crowns, with a FlexRing shock absorber and a quick-release rubber strap.[1]

Which is a useful name this particular fortnight. At **Phillips' New York Sessions**, concluded **9 October**, lot 22 — a **Voutilainen 28Sport in steel, number five of eight** — sold for **$1,016,000** against an estimate of $120,000 to $240,000. The next four lots were a long way behind: two F.P. Journes at $304,800, another at $241,300, and a Jaeger-LeCoultre Atmos Marqueterie at $152,400. The man who sets the finishing standard for a CHF 82,000 watch just did four times high estimate on his own.[2]

8×

WHAT LOT 22 MADE OVER ITS LOW ESTIMATE: $1,016,000 AGAINST $120,000. NO OTHER LOT IN THE SALE CLEARED A THIRD OF IT[2]

ALSO WORTH THE SHELF

Urwerk threw out its own signature. The UR-300 "Time Quantum", unveiled 15 October at **CHF 168,000** before tax in two runs of twenty-five, abandons the orbiting satellites for a T-shaped frame carrying **four rotating three-sided hour prisms** that reconfigure in a single jump every hour; minutes read across a 108-degree arc. Case 45.2 by 58.8 by 18.25mm.[3]

Technics' flagship headphone got its reviews. The EAH-A1000, US$449.99, launched 29 September; Engadget scored it **8.9** on 16 October — "superb sound", "excellent ANC", against "pricey" and "finicky multi-point Bluetooth", with **45 hours** on ANC. Trusted Reviews finds the shells "a little more plasticky than its premium price implies". **No Singapore price exists.**[4]

THE CHATTER · THE COLLECTOR'S CASE FOR 42

Watchonista's collector column, written by an owner of an LM Perpetual EVO, argues 42mm may be the Legacy Machine's right size and admits the update tempts him to buy again. SJX, which handled the watch, keeps two reservations on the record: it is **"still a six-figure proposition in dollar terms"**, and the hand winding means constant use of the crowns while the EVO strap system locks an owner into MB&F's own ecosystem.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · MINIMALISM AS A MARKETING PLAN

Ariel Adams of aBlogToWatch, who handled it on announcement day, is unconvinced the case is a case at all: **"To me however, the EVO case is not that different from the Legacy Machine case,"** and the whole exercise **"feels like an exercise in intentional minimalism to make MB&F more mainstream"** — which, he adds, **"conflicts with the story of the brand that I have in my mind."** His specific complaint is the one that matters on a watch sold on dial theatre: **"the hands and dials feel more generic than I would hope from an MB&F."** MB&F's own product page refused this desk with a 403, so every figure above is from two independent hands-on accounts rather than the maker.[6]

SOURCES 1 Two independent hands-on accounts of the 13 October announcement, read at source, agreeing on both Swiss-franc and both dollar prices, the dimensions, the limitation, the calibre changes, the water resistance and the Voutilainen and Rochat attributions. **MB&F's own product page returned 403 to this desk, so no figure here comes from the maker directly.** 2 **Phillips' own results page for The New York Sessions, read at source**, for lot 22's hammer, its estimate range and the next four lots. Phillips publishes no sale total on that page. 3 Monochrome, read at source, for every UR-300 specification, the price, the two runs of twenty-five and the quoted reservation — including the internal contradiction between its body text and its own spec table. **US pricing is unconfirmed: two listings disagree by more than twenty thousand dollars and neither is printed.** 4 Engadget, 16 October, read at source, for the score, both pro and con lists and the battery and connection figures; What Hi-Fi? and Trusted Reviews for the two quoted verdicts. **The single Singapore listing found carries an implausible price and no stock, so this desk prints no local price.** 5 Watchonista, SJX and HauteTime, read at source. 6 aBlogToWatch, 13 October, read at source, for all four quoted passages. **Hodinkee and Watchuseek were not relied on; two watch-trade hosts refused this desk with a 403 and a 429.**

SCREEN & SOUND · FONTAINES D.C.

Fontaines D.C. released Dopamine Chamber on 16 October to a Metascore of 84

Fourteen of seventeen critics were positive, none negative. Paste dissented at C-plus; NME, which this desk reported reviewing four days early, publishes no star rating at all.

Fontaines D.C. released their fifth album, **Dopamine Chamber**, on **Friday 16 October** through XL Recordings, produced by **James Ford**. It carries a Metacritic score of **84, "universal acclaim", from seventeen critics** — fourteen positive, three mixed, none negative — and a critic score of **83 from twenty-four reviews** on the second aggregator this desk checked. The Independent, musicOMH, NME and The Guardian are all logged at 100; Pitchfork at 78; Paste, at 58, is the floor.[1]

Two corrections to this book's own record come with it. No. 134 reported that NME had published five stars **four days before release**; the review is real, dated **12 October** by Andrew Trendell, and calls the record **"an extraordinary record for extraordinary times"** by a band who have **"secured themselves as the definitive band of this decade"**. But **NME's own page carries no star rating**: the five stars is an aggregator's normalisation of a 100, and this desk should not have called it a star count. And the Metascore No. 134 held open is now in hand at 84 — though honestly only at one remove, because Metacritic's music pages refused us while its film pages served.[1][2]

AND AT THE BOX OFFICE

Aaron Sorkin's Facebook sequel opened fifth. The Social Reckoning took **$5,018,263** across 2,606 North American theatres on the 9–11 October weekend — a per-theatre average of **$1,926** — against a reported $30m budget. The weekend's winner, **Other Mommy**, took **$27,805,825** from 3,365 sites, five and a half times as much. Metacritic, which did serve this desk on film, puts the Sorkin picture at **51 from fifty-seven critics**, "mixed or average"; its user score is 6.4 from thirty-three ratings. **The Social Network** opened to **$22.6m** in 2010 and finished at $225m. **CinemaScore is contested: most outlets report B-minus, one reports a soft D-plus; this desk does not resolve it.**[3]

YouTube Music began labelling AI-generated songs. From **14 October**, a label appears on the player page where generative AI "played a significant role"; partners declare "Fully", "Partly" or "No Gen AI" through standard industry templates and YouTube labels unilaterally where no declaration arrives. The hole is the money: **neither the blog post nor the help page says whether a label changes recommendations or payouts**. Tidal already excludes wholly-AI tracks from royalty attribution; Deezer reported receiving nearly **90,000 fully AI-generated tracks a day** in July.[4]

THE CHATTER · DAY ONE, AND THIN

A record released on a Friday has no settled audience verdict by Saturday, and this one is split in the places that were readable. On the album-aggregator comment layer one listener predicts it will be **"the most overhyped album of the year"** while others say it deserves to be heard on its own terms; on the band's own store page the division is between "lacks the memorability of earlier records" and "still an enjoyable listen". **That is a first-day sample of a dozen or so, and Reddit refused this desk, so it is reported as what it is: not a verdict.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ONE CRITIC WHO SAID NO

Grant Sharples, writing in Paste on 14 October, graded it C-plus — the only mixed-or-worse review with a named argument. The record, he writes, **"isn't nearly as revolutionary as its predecessor"**, and **"the otherwise heady studio trickery does little to push Fontaines D.C.'s envelope."** His sharpest line is the one that should survive the acclaim: **"The processes behind these new songs are often more interesting to think about than to listen to."** Pitchfork, at 78, lands in the same neighbourhood from the other side, calling it **"cruel, beautiful feel-bad music"** that **"could have done with not being rushed out"**.[6]

SOURCES 1 **The Metacritic album page, verified at one remove only: its music pages returned 403 to both a plain fetch and a browser-headed request, so the 84, the seventeen-critic count and the fourteen-three-nil split come from a search engine's verbatim quotation of that page rather than a direct read. The second aggregator's 83 from twenty-four reviews is in the same position.** This desk prints the figures with that limitation stated rather than implying a direct read. A third aggregator was unreachable: its TLS certificate has expired. 2 **NME's own review page, read at source**, dated 12 October 2026, for both quoted passages — and for the absence of any star rating, which is the correction. 3 **Two independent box-office databases, read at source** and agreeing to the dollar, for both films' three-day grosses, theatre counts and averages; **Metacritic's film page, read at source**, for 51 from fifty-seven and the user score. The 2010 comparison is from the same databases. 4 **YouTube's own blog post, read at source**, for the label, the quoted threshold and the rollout; a music-industry trade outlet, read at source, for the declaration mechanics. **The absence of any statement on recommendations or royalties is a property of both pages.** 5 Two comment layers, read at source, on a day-one sample of roughly a dozen. **Reddit refused this desk again.** 6 Paste, 14 October, read at source, for the grade and all three quoted passages; Pitchfork's 7.8 and both quoted lines via the aggregator page, not read at source.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE KAROLINSKA TWINS

A Karolinska study of 21,797 twins finds shared family factors explain much

Published in Nature Human Behaviour on 8 October. Comparing identical twins to each other cut the association from 0.30 to 0.24 — smaller, and still there.

A team led by **Tong Gong** at the Karolinska Institutet published in **Nature Human Behaviour on 8 October** a co-twin analysis of recreational screen use and internalising problems, drawn from the Swedish CATSS twin cohort: **21,797 twins** at the age-nine wave, 16,027 at fifteen, 13,050 at eighteen, 5,772 at twenty-four. The design is the point. By comparing one twin with their own co-twin, it nets out shared genes and shared upbringing — the confounders every cross-sectional screen-time study leaves in.[1]

The headline figures, as standardised betas. For heavy weekend **interactive** use — more than six hours a day against two or fewer — and depressive symptoms at eighteen: **0.30 across all twins, 0.26 within fraternal pairs, 0.24 within identical pairs**, where the last confidence interval runs from 0.05 to 0.43 and so nearly touches zero. The association shrinks when you control for the family. It does not disappear. Interactive use — gaming, chatting, browsing — consistently out-predicted passive viewing, and the sex split was wide: **0.37 to 0.49 for girls against 0.18 to 0.24 for boys**.[1]

Two things this desk will not paper over. First, the clinical results come from the **full cohort only**, because there were too few diagnosed events for a co-twin comparison — so the striking hazard ratios, **1.86** for heavy interactive weekday use at fifteen and 1.57 for heavy passive use, carry none of the design's protection. Second, and larger: **this cohort's data collection began in 2004**, before smartphones and social media were central, and the authors say so. The screen measures are crude self-reports that capture neither content nor motivation, response rates fell from about seventy per cent to fifty, and smartphone use is probably under-reported.[1]

0.24

THE ASSOCIATION INSIDE IDENTICAL-TWIN PAIRS, DOWN FROM 0.30 ACROSS ALL TWINS. ITS CONFIDENCE INTERVAL STARTS AT 0.05[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE AUTHORS ACTUALLY SAID

The caution in circulation comes from inside the paper, which is unusual and worth crediting. **Tong Gong**, the corresponding author, says the association **"may in some cases have been overestimated"** because it **"has not been possible to fully account for shared family factors"** — and then, carefully, that **"the correlations did not disappear entirely, but they did become significantly weaker,"** which suggests **"both genes and upbringing play an important role."** Her co-author **Emma Frans** draws the policy conclusion: **"Future recommendations should not focus solely on how much time children and young people spend in front of screens."** The team also states plainly that the findings do *not* mean screen time is irrelevant.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · IT DOES NOT OBSERVE A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD

The honest limit on this paper for a reader with a child in the first years of secondary school: **screen use was measured at nine, fifteen and eighteen**, and symptoms at nine, fifteen, eighteen and twenty-four. A twelve-year-old sits in the gap. The study brackets that age; it does not observe it, and anyone quoting it at a parent of a twelve-year-old is interpolating.[3]

General guidance, not medical advice. The usable conclusion is narrower and more actionable than the headlines: what the family does appears to matter at least as much as the clock, the interactive hours matter more than the passive ones, and reverse causation is real but small — higher symptoms at nine or fifteen predicted heavier later screen use at an odds ratio of just **1.03**.[1]

SOURCES 1 **Gong, Frans, Ohlis and colleagues, Nature Human Behaviour, published online 8 October 2026, doi 10.1038/s41562-026-02607-0 — the citation, funding, design, every wave size, every standardised beta and confidence interval, the sex split, the hazard ratios, the reverse-direction odds ratio and all of the authors' own limitations read at source from the full text and the institutional release.** Funded principally by the Marianne and Marcus Wallenberg Foundation and the Swedish Brain Foundation; one co-author declares pharmaceutical grants outside this work. **That the clinical hazard ratios come from the full cohort and not from discordant pairs, and that the cohort began collecting in 2004, are the authors' own statements.** 2 The Karolinska Institutet's own release, read at source, for both authors' quoted remarks and the team's guard-rail. 3 A 2026 lecture and accompanying university material, read at source. **Dated April to June 2026 depending on the source: it is background on the literature, not a response to this paper. This desk found no named outside researcher publicly criticising the Karolinska study, and says so rather than commissioning a counter-voice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · AGE ASSURANCE

A Turkish under-15 social-media ban takes force on 1 November

The Philippines, Mexico and Germany moved the same week. Singapore's own tiered scheme keeps 13-to-17s online and its legislation is expected in early 2027, not now.

Four governments moved on children's social-media access inside a week. **Turkey** published a ban on accounts for under-fifteens on **10 October**, in force **1 November**. The **Philippines** House approved a bill on the **12th** barring under-thirteens, still needing Senate reconciliation. **Mexico**'s president signed a decree on about the **14th** requiring Meta, TikTok and X to protect minors from harmful content, with one month to comply. **Germany** has a proposal to bar under-thirteens. The Turkish item is single-sourced in this desk's reading and is printed as such.[1]

What a Singapore parent should take from that week is mostly a date. There was **no Singapore announcement on children online between 10 and 17 October** — this desk read the ministry's own newsroom and every October item concerns cyber-security week, small-business digitisation or a dialect drama. The live Singapore position remains the one set out at the **23 August** National Day Rally: more reliable age checks, and a **tiered model** keeping under-thirteens off designated services while **13-to-17s keep access** where platforms provide an age-appropriate experience. Platforms that will not comply may be made to raise their minimum age from 13 to 18. The first six designated services are Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, HardwareZone, X and YouTube; **legislation is expected in early 2027**, covering age verification, daily time limits and restrictions on infinite scroll, autoplay and messages from unknown accounts.[2]

So for a twelve-year-old the relevant tier is the **13-to-17 band**, the relevant year is 2027, and nothing changes this term. The other thing readers will be told about is already decided and not yet in effect: Meta's settlement with a bipartisan group of state attorneys general, announced **26 August** and worth up to **US$17.1bn** over ten years, sets a default **two-hour combined daily cap** across Instagram and Facebook, a midnight-to-six block, notifications muted from eight to three, break prompts every fifteen minutes, like counts hidden by default and most provisions binding for ten years — with **direct messages excluded throughout**, and most provisions not taking effect for six months, which is late February 2027.[3]

1 in 5

CHILDREN AGED 8 TO 12 WHO FALL ASLEEP WATCHING A SCREEN, RISING TO 37 PER CENT OF YOUNG TEENS UP TO 15[4]

THE CHATTER · THE SURVEY THAT DOES COVER HER AGE

CyberSafeKids in Ireland published a survey of **1,200 children on 16 October** — and unlike the Karolinska cohort on p12, it squarely covers a twelve-year-old. **One in five eight-to-twelves falls asleep watching a screen**, rising to 37 per cent of young teens; **about a third of primary-age children have no time limits at all**, rising to about two-thirds at secondary; and **more than half of young people say their parents are on devices "a lot of the time" or "all the time"** when they are together. The family psychotherapist **Richard Hogan** draws the obvious conclusion: **"This means engaging with our kids before our phones in the morning and during the day."**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · BANS ARE EASIER TO PASS THAN TO MEASURE

Four jurisdictions legislated in one week and not one of them published a measure of effect. This book reported in No. 133 that a study of school phone bans found they moved nothing measurable, and No. 124 noted that Singapore's own education ministry has published no outcome measure for its January 2026 phone rule. Against that, the only hard evidence in the week is a survey finding that the adults are on their phones too. Verian polling found **68 per cent of Singaporeans support a minimum age of 16** — which is polling, not policy, and support is not an outcome either. What would settle the question: a published before-and-after on any one of these regimes.[2][4]

SOURCES 1 A policy-news outlet, read at source, for the Turkish publication and commencement dates. **Single-sourced: the official gazette citation was not reached, so the item is printed with that limitation.** The Philippine, Mexican and German items via regional and wire coverage of the same week. 2 **The ministry's own newsroom, read directly** — the absence of any October item on children online is a property of that listing. The tiered model, the six designated services and the early-2027 legislative timetable from the August rally and ministerial statements. The Verian figure is published polling. 3 Reporting of the 26 August settlement, read at source, for the dollar figure, every default setting, the ten-year binding period, the exclusion of direct messages and the six-month lead time. **It is not this week's news and is printed as what is coming.** 4 The CyberSafeKids survey published 16 October 2026, read at source, for the sample, all three findings and the quoted psychotherapist. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · SYNCHRONOUS TIGHTENING

The US ten-year fell 15 basis points in the worst PPI week of 2026

US producer prices came in at 1.3 per cent on the month against 0.6 expected, four-fifths of it energy. The long end rallied anyway, and Kevin Warsh named the regime in Bangkok.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics published September producer prices on **Thursday 15 October**: final demand up **1.3 per cent on the month and 6.3 on the year**, against expectations of 0.6 and 5.5. Goods rose 2.6 per cent, of which **energy supplied more than four-fifths**; wholesale gasoline rose **20.3 per cent**. The consumer print the day before told the same story from the other end: headline **0.6 per cent on the month, 3.7 on the year**, with retail gasoline up 9.1 per cent doing about half of it — while **core was only 0.3 and 2.6**.[1]

And the long end rallied into it. The ten-year Treasury went from **5.24 to 5.09 per cent** on the week, the thirty-year from 5.60 to **5.43**, the two-year from 4.80 to 4.74 — so the **2s10s flattened nine basis points to 35**, a continuation of the bull-flattener this desk recorded in No. 133, now driven by news that looks like its opposite. Read plainly, the bond market voted for demand destruction over inflation persistence: oil near a hundred and ten dollars with a policy rate just under four is a tax on growth, not a reason to price a higher terminal rate. A global aggregate bond proxy gained **0.87 per cent** on the week.[2]

Fed chair **Kevin Warsh**, at the IMF meetings in Bangkok on **Friday 16 October**, gave no rate signal and named the regime instead: **"it was a synchronous tightening in monetary policy in most places around the world… And that means there's no free riders."** The funds target stands at **3.75 to 4 per cent** after September's first increase since 2023, with sixteen of eighteen forecast-submitting officials expecting one more this year.[3]

THE BOARD · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

VWRA	$191.68	▼ 0.94% wk
Global agg (AGGU)	$5.78	▲ 0.87% wk
US 10-year	5.09%	▼ 15bp wk
USD/SGD	1.2796	▼ 0.14%
Brent	$109.66	▲ 3.53%
Gold, spot	$4,165.52	▼ 0.13%
Bitcoin	$81,585	▼ 0.91%

Straits Times Index 5,415.53, up 0.22 per cent, confirmed across three sources. Weekly moves are given only where a daily history was readable. Not advice.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE SHOCK WAS ACTUALLY PAID

Not in the index. On Thursday the Kospi fell **7.57 per cent to 5,554.22**, tripping a circuit breaker — its seventh straight loss, about **21 per cent** over the streak — with Samsung Electronics down 9.5 and SK Hynix 11.1.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO DISSENTS, OPPOSITE DIRECTIONS

On the AI de-rate, **Samik Chatterjee of JPMorgan** reiterated overweight on CoreWeave on **16 October**, arguing data-centre demand **"is robust and has improved in recent months, rather than moderated"**. On Singapore, **Deepali Bhargava of ING** says the 14 October hold was not a turn: **"we do not view this as a dovish pivot,"** and **"we continue to see the balance of risks to inflation as modestly tilted to the upside"** — she expects core at the top of MAS's own range and tightening in January.[25]

One local number dwarfed all of it: Singapore's non-oil domestic exports rose **68.4 per cent** in September against a Bloomberg median of 32.2. The build-out is accelerating through this port in the week its funding was repriced.[6]

SOURCES 1 **The Bureau of Labor Statistics' own producer-price and consumer-price releases of 15 and 14 October 2026, read at source**, for every index and component; the expectations and the retail-sales and claims prints via a wire recap read at source. 2 **The US Treasury's own daily par yield curve for October 2026, read at source**, for every yield and the derived 2s10s; fund and commodity levels from two independent quote services agreeing to within cents. **Weekly moves for the dollar index, both currency pairs, gold, bitcoin and the Straits Times Index are NOT printed: this desk's usual daily-history source reset every connection and an alternative 404'd. They are held, not estimated.** A crude-oil discrepancy between a contract quote and a spot reference is noted rather than resolved. 3 Press accounts of the Bangkok session across four outlets; **no transcript was available, so the quotations are press-reported.** The policy state and September minutes read at source; **the futures probability is snippet-sourced because that host returned 403.** 4 Two Korean outlets, read at source; the trillion-dollar figure is snippet-sourced from a host that refused us. 5 A market-news host for the JPMorgan note; **ING's own research page, read at source**; MAS's own statement for the quoted sentence. 6 Four secondaries agreeing on the trade figures. **Reddit refused this desk again.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · PIGEON RACING

A Belgian hen called New Kim sold for €1.6m to a Chinese buyer

Bidding opened at €200 on 15 November 2020. Five years on, Britain's governing body counts 11,742 members, down 14 per cent in a year, and its trade paper is losing 63 subscribers a month.

A fancier keeps a loft of racing homers. The birds are **basketed** at the club, trucked hundreds of kilometres away and **liberated** together at a set time. They fly home. Speed is scored not in kilometres an hour but in **metres per minute** — the distance from the liberation point to your own loft, divided by the time it took — and an RFID ring crossing an antenna in the landing board writes the arrival to an electronic clock. The bird leaves your hand in France and lands on a shed you built. Nothing you did makes it come back, and it comes back.[1]

Nobody can tell you how. After fifty years of experiments the sun compass, an olfactory map, landmark memory and something magnetic all have evidence, and the newest piece is the least expected: in **June 2026**, in *Science*, a University of Copenhagen team reported that **superparamagnetic macrophages — immune cells — in the pigeon liver** are required for finding magnetic direction. Deplete them and **"pigeons flying under overcast conditions lacked their usual orientation capabilities"**, while orientation was unimpaired when the sun was visible. The sun is primary; the magnet is the cloudy-day backup, and it may live in the liver rather than the beak.[2][3]

The scale at the top is hard to credit. At the **Barcelona International** this year, the sport's blue riband, **16,278 birds** were liberated at **07:45**; the winner was a hen called **Barcelona Queen**, who covered **1,075.5 kilometres at 1,082 metres per minute** — 65km/h averaged over a thousand kilometres. The same race has been won at 1,266 and at 800: velocity is almost entirely a wind story.[4]

And then there is the money. On **15 November 2020** a hen called **New Kim**, lot one of a 445-bird dispersal sale in Berlaar, sold for **€1.6m** to an anonymous Chinese buyer, after bidding opened at **€200**. Within ninety minutes a South African group had bid €1.31m; two Chinese collectors then fought it out. The chairman said the buyer was the same collector who had paid **€1,252,000 for a cock called Armando** the year before. Last November a hen of the same line made **€400,000**, again to China.[5]

€200

WHERE NEW KIM'S BIDDING OPENED. IT CLOSED EIGHT THOUSAND TIMES HIGHER[5]

THE CHATTER · THE MAP OF THE NEXT TWO PAGES

The spine of this descent is a contradiction: the sport is **collapsing where it was invented and booming where it is bought**. Britain's Royal Pigeon Racing Association told its own annual meeting in February that membership stands at **11,742, a 14 per cent fall**, with ring sales down from 649,405 to 619,075; and that its trade paper is **"in a critical position with 63 subscribers being lost each month"**.[6][7]

THE SCEPTIC · STRIP OUT ASIA AND THE MARKET IS €500

The millions are one buyer, one country and one auction house. The ordinary market is published and modest: Herbots of Halle-Booienhoven sells **fixed-price descendants of the famous birds** — an inbred Kannibaal at **€500**, an inbred Kittel at €500, a full brother to Olympic Liam reduced from €700 to **€600**, a brother to the 46th International Barcelona at **€300**.[8]

SOURCES 1 **The Royal Pigeon Racing Association's own beginner's guide, August 2025, read at source**, for basketing, trapping and the racing year; the velocity definition and the antenna mechanism from the same guide and the equipment makers' own pages. 2 **The University of Copenhagen's own research page of 24 June 2026, read at source**, for the finding and both quoted passages (Lisowski et al., *Science* 392, 985–991, 2026). **The paper itself was not read, and the university page lists neither the co-author set nor the number of birds.** 3 A Queen's University Belfast publication record, read at source, for the null magnetic-pulse result; the olfactory work via a public movement-data repository. 4 A Belgian race-results page, read at source, for the liberation time, the distance, the bird count, the winner and the velocity. **It sits on a test subdomain, so this desk flags it as needing confirmation against the federation; the comparative velocities from other years are single-sourced.** 5 **Belgium's public broadcaster, 15 November 2020, read at source**, for the price, the opening bid, the ninety-minute bidding, the Armando comparison and the buyer attribution; a Brussels English-language daily, 16 November 2025, read at source, for New Kim 3 and the quoted comparison. **The auction house's own pages were unreadable behind a bot challenge throughout, so no figure here is from the seller directly, and the 2020 record is properly the highest price paid online.** 6 **The RPRA's own annual general meeting minutes of 27 February 2026, read at source as a PDF**, for the membership, the percentage fall, both ring-sale totals and all three subscription figures with the quoted characterisation. 7 The Chinese membership figure is reported via a wire-derived carry and dates from 2017–20; **no current figure exists in open sources and none is presented as current.** 8 **Herbots' own fixed-price sale page, read at source, 17 October 2026**, for every bird and every price.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR

Benzing prices the M3 clock at £865; the Blackpool show takes off £700

A serious British timing install runs £1,215 to £1,350; the RPRA puts a whole first year at £600 to £1,500. A Taiwanese company runs the live tracking for the world's one-loft races.

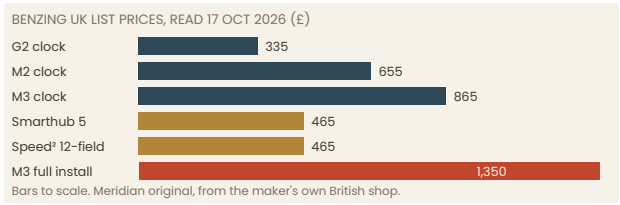
The real gear argument in this sport is not the loft, it is the clock. **Benzing**, of Gantner Pigeon Systems, is the reference: the **M3** touchscreen at **£865** on its own British shop, the M2 at £655, the entry G2 at £335, a Smarthub 5 at £465, and antenna pads from **£185 for one field to £465 for a twelve-field Speed²**. Bundled, a G2 with hub and a one-field pad is **£665**, an M3 with hub and a four-field pad **£1,215**, and the full twelve-field install **£1,350**. There is a trade-in — any old Benzing for a new M3 at **£635** — and a show special at £1,086, which tells you where this equipment is actually sold.[1]

In America the same clock is **US$1,076** at Siegel, with complete systems to $1,612.95 and a **$58.95 annual activation** for the at-home service — the subscription layer, in black and white. And the detail that locates the culture: Siegel **no longer accepts online payment for Benzing clocking items**. Orders go by telephone or posted cheque. The German competition is reticent in a different way: **TauRIS**, **TIPES** and **Bricon** all publish catalogues and **no prices at all**, and **Unikon's** own domain fails its TLS certificate.[2]

Against which the honest cost of starting, published by the federation itself, is modest. The RPRA's beginner guide puts **year one at £600 to £1,500**: a loft at **£300 to £1,000-plus**, baskets £40 to £100, **corn and grit at £40 to £60 a month** — the real recurring cost, £480 to £720 a year — membership £35, and birds at £20 to £100 each, **often gifted by the club**. It puts the electronic clock in **months eleven and twelve**, not month one.[3]

£40,000

THE REPORTED COST OF THE LATE QUEEN'S SANDRINGHAM LOFT, AGAINST THE RPRA'S £300 FOR A BEGINNER'S[4]



The clock is the cheap part. *Meridian* original, from list prices read at the maker's own British shop.

Widowhood — the birds are separated by sex for the whole week before a race and shown their partner briefly at basketing. Usually flown with cocks, sometimes hens; **double widowhood** is both. **The Natural system** races mated pairs motivated by the nest, timed to **nest condition**. **Roundabout** flies both sexes so they never meet. **The darkness system** keeps young birds under shortened daylight in spring to delay the moult so they race in full wing. **Eye sign** is the belief that the iris predicts merit — still its own chapter in the literature, with **no evidential basis in anything this desk read**.[5]

THE CHATTER · SYSTEMS DO NOT MAKE A CHAMPION

The sport argues about husbandry the way other hobbies argue about cables, and the most honest line comes from inside it. **Bob Rowland**, writing for a fanciers' site, holds that **"the best system is the one that allows you the most opportunity to WIN"** and then settles it: **"Systems do not make a bad pigeon a champion."** On ventilation both camps agree draught is the hazard and differ only on whether a loft front can stay open all year; birds have no sweat glands and thermoregulate by breathing, so the target is a steady low-velocity exchange.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY PUBLISHES THE FAILURE DATA

Two awkward absences. First, the reliability conversation about these clocks **is no longer publicly readable**: the forum where it happened now sits behind a bot-paywall returning a payment-required error, Reddit refused this desk outright, and **no manufacturer publishes failure data**.[7]

SOURCES 1 **The official Benzing UK shop and its antenna category, read at source 17 October 2026**, for every model and pad price, the bundles, the trade-in and the show special. 2 **Siegel Pigeons' own product page, read at source**, for the US price, the annual activation fee and the statement that clocking items are no longer paid for online; **TauRIS's, TIPES's and Bricon's own sites, read at source**, for their catalogues and the absence of any prices, and **Unikon's domain, which fails its TLS certificate** — the second-hand figure is from a live auction listing. 3 **The RPRA's own beginner's guide, August 2025, read at source as a PDF**, for the year-one budget, the gifting note and the month-eleven advice on timing systems. 4 A 2015 report attributing the loft figure to the association's own manager. **It is eleven years old; no bespoke loft-builder's price list could be verified, because every British builder's domain this desk probed failed to resolve.** 5 A fanciers' site, read at source, for the Rowland quotations; two husbandry articles for the ventilation positions and the physiology. 6 A 2008 regional newspaper report and a 2013–14 discussion thread, both read at source, for the quoted sentiments and their dates. 7 **The forum carrying the sport's equipment talk now returns a payment-required error, and Reddit refused this desk for a third consecutive issue, so no current owner sentiment on these clocks is reported.**

THE DEEP END · THE LOSSES

Rule 7 of Singapore's Pigeons Rules requires the birds be kept confined

Rule 7 requires the birds be kept confined; rule 8 bars releasing them in any public place. So the only legal way in from here is to post a bird to Tenerife.

Read against Singapore Statutes Online as at **17 October 2026**, the *Animals and Birds (Pigeons) Rules* make the answer plain. Rule 3 requires a licence to keep, harbour, roost, nest or breed pigeons on any premises — expressly including **"any house, hut, shed, cage, coop, eave, ceiling, enclosure or structure whether roofed or not"** — on pain of a fine up to **$500**. The licence costs **$50** and the Licensing Officer may refuse, or revoke, **"without assigning any reason"**. Separately, no more than **ten** non-commercial poultry may be kept on any premises, and the definition includes domestic pigeons.[1]

Two rules settle it. Rule 7: licensed premises **"shall be constructed in such a manner that the pigeons are kept confined within the premises."** Rule 8: a licensee **"shall not let loose… in any public place any pigeon kept by him."** Loft-flying, training tosses and racing are therefore unavailable to a private keeper here; doing it at all would need an exemption under rule 18, which the Officer may grant to a person, society or association.[1]

Which leaves the route the sport built for people who cannot keep birds: the **one-loft race**. You send a squab to a neutral loft, someone else trains it with everyone else's, and it races once for a pot. A listing for the **Derby Arona** on Tenerife quotes **€370 for one active bird plus four reserves, transport included**. And the live tracking it all runs on comes from **Avance Technology of New Taipei City**, whose public race board this week carried races from Idaho, Utah, the Philippines, Indonesia, Mexico and South Africa.[2]

€370

ONE ACTIVE BIRD PLUS FOUR RESERVES INTO A TENERIFE ONE-LOFT RACE, SHIPPING INCLUDED. THE SINGAPOREAN'S ONLY LEGAL WAY IN[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FEDERATIONS NOW WRITE TO THEIR OWN

The fairest thing available to the sport is not its 2013 rebuttal but what its chief executive published this year. **Chris Sutton of the RPRA, "Racing in High Temperatures", 26 June 2026**: **"the welfare of our pigeons must remain our foremost consideration"**; heightened caution **whenever temperatures approach or exceed 30°C**; early-morning liberations, unrestricted water, appropriate basket densities, and **"consideration of shortening, postponing or cancelling races where conditions present an unacceptable welfare risk"**.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY PUBLISHES AN AUDITED LOSS SERIES

The welfare argument is real and the numbers are contested, so here are both. **PETA**, campaigning, says of cross-Channel racing that **"an average of 75 per cent of the birds taking part… never make it home"**, with one race from Fougères at **nearly 90 per cent**. The five British and Welsh unions answered in 2013 that **"none of the UK homing unions condone acts of cruelty against pigeons"** and that **"Losses do occur during races for a myriad of differing reasons"**. On doping, Belgium's own reviewer reports that most antibiotics in the sport **"are acquired illegally"**, and that testing winners is near-useless because most banned substances show only in samples taken before basketing.[4][5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Koi keeping (nishikigoi) — named bloodlines, six-figure champions, and a Singapore trade.

Carnivorous plants (Nepenthes) — named clones, CITES, and a genus native to this region.

Turntable cartridges & tonearms — retipping specialists and a measurement war.

SOURCES 1 **Singapore Statutes Online, the Animals and Birds (Pigeons) Rules, current as at 17 October 2026, read at source** — rule 3 and its definition of premises, rules 4(2) and 6 on refusal and revocation without reason, rule 5 on the fee, rule 7 on confinement, rule 8 on release and rule 18 on exemption; **the ten-bird cap and the inclusion of domestic pigeons in "poultry" from the Prevention of Avian Disease in Non-Commercial Poultry Rules, read at source**. The deletion of the former rule 11 is recorded in the 2020 amending instrument. **No Singapore club was found; that is an unverified absence, not a proven one.** 2 A one-loft shipment listing and historical reporting, both single-sourced: **the South African organiser's site was blocked, so no 2026 fee or purse is printed**; the live-race board and the platform company's address read at source on 17 October. 3 **The RPRA chief executive's own article of 26 June 2026, read at source.** 4 A campaigning organisation's investigations, **labelled advocacy**; the five unions' joint statement of 27 March 2013, read at source. **The one non-advocacy loss figure is snippet-level; neither side publishes an audited series.** 5 A 2022 peer-reviewed review of doping in racing pigeons, read at source, including its author's own caution that his table is indicative only.

FITNESS · THE STEP COUNT

The American College of Cardiology puts the useful step count at 5,000 to 7,000

Its scientific statement, published in JACC on 15 October, says meaningful benefit arrives well below ten thousand. The same fortnight, the exercise-snack literature lost its headline result.

The American College of Cardiology published a scientific statement on exercise prescription in the *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* on **Thursday 15 October**, and the number in it retires a figure that was never evidence. Roughly **5,000 to 7,000 steps a day** is associated with clinically important improvements and substantial reductions in cardiovascular and all-cause mortality for many adults; meaningful benefit is achievable **well below ten thousand steps**. The writing committee's chair, **Jonathan N. Myers** of the Palo Alto VA, puts it plainly: **"The most important message is that some activity is better than none,"** and **"Exercise is one of the most effective therapies available for preventing and managing CVD, yet it remains underutilized in routine care."**[1]

Three other instructions matter for a mid-forties reader with a wrist full of sensors. Prescriptions should be individualised, not set by a round number. **Resistance training should be added to aerobic work for most adults.** And **routine exercise testing is not required before starting** for most asymptomatic or stable people, which removes the commonest excuse. Low cardiorespiratory fitness, it notes, predicts cardiovascular disease about as strongly as smoking or hypertension.[1]

Against that, the week's most-shared idea quietly failed its own test. A systematic review and meta-analysis of **"exercise snacks"** — very short, scattered bouts — pooling **22 studies and 994 sedentary adults**, reported a large effect on peak oxygen uptake: **Hedges' g of 1.24**. Then its own publication-bias test flagged asymmetry at **p below 0.01**, and after trim-and-fill the effect fell to **g 0.62, with a confidence interval from minus 0.59 to 1.83 and p of 0.32**. The flagship finding is no longer statistically significant. On body fat, muscle mass, strength and insulin there was **no effect at all**; GRADE certainty was moderate for one outcome and low or very low for the rest.[2]

1.24 → 0.62

THE EXERCISE-SNACK EFFECT ON PEAK OXYGEN UPTAKE BEFORE AND AFTER CORRECTING FOR PUBLICATION BIAS. THE CORRECTED FIGURE IS NOT SIGNIFICANT[2]

WHAT TO ACTUALLY TRY

Keep the snacks for glucose, not for strength. The most consistent signal in that analysis was blood glucose, at **g minus 0.83**, and the authors' own July trial found snacks feasible in daily life and improving physical capacity in adults with non-insulin-treated type 2 diabetes — a narrower and more defensible claim than the headline. So: stair climbs or sit-to-stands in the gaps between meetings, for the glucose curve. **The resistance session stays on the calendar as its own appointment**, because the snacks demonstrably do not replace it — and the step floor sits around seven thousand, not ten. General guidance, not medical advice.[2][3]

THE CHATTER · A METHOD WARNING, NOT A STUDY

A note on where fitness "news" comes from. Three stories carried October 2026 datelines this fortnight that are not new. A headline on reversing muscle ageing belongs to a paper **published 24 November 2025** — and it is fruit-fly and mouse work with no human sample.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE INVENTORS ARE THE BEST CRITICS

The researchers who built this literature are the most careful about it. **Martin Gibala** of McMaster and **Jonathan Little** of UBC Okanagan list the limits in their own recent work: no wearable heart-rate verification, no familiarisation session, short interventions, and real difficulty assessing intensity outside a laboratory.[5]

SOURCES 1 The 2026 American College of Cardiology scientific statement on exercise prescription, published in its own journal on 15 October 2026 (doi 10.1016/j.jacc.2026.09.008). **The journal refused this desk with a 403, so the contents and both quotations were read at source from the College's own journal-scan page and corroborated by a medical-news outlet.** 2 **Qi, Wang, Xu and colleagues, *Frontiers in Nutrition* 13 (2026), doi 10.3389/fnut.2026.1883923, 28 September 2026, read at source** — the study and participant counts, every effect size, the Egger's test, the trim-and-fill result and all GRADE ratings. **It is nineteen days old; the news cycle around it is in window, and its authors disclose that registration post-dates their search.** 3 The same authors' July 2026 randomised trial, doi 10.1111/dom.71052. 4 Publication records for three recycled studies, read at source, establishing their 2025 dates. **No figure from the fruit-fly and mouse paper is printed as applying to humans.** 5 The named researchers' own papers and a 2026 narrative review, read at source. **This desk found no commentary from the longevity commentariat and no cardiologist criticism of the step figure, and says so rather than commissioning one. General guidance, not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · AIR NEW ZEALAND

Air New Zealand returns to Singapore–Christchurch non-stop on 28 October

Three a week on a 787-9, its first Singapore flight on the route since February 2020. With Singapore Airlines, fifteen weekly non-stops at peak.

Air New Zealand resumes **Singapore–Christchurch non-stop on 28 October 2026**, three times a week to 26 March, for the first time since February 2020. **NZ67** leaves Singapore at 00:40 and lands at 15:35, nine hours fifty-five, on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays; **NZ66** leaves Christchurch at 17:20 and arrives 22:55. The aircraft is a **787-9** carrying the airline's newest cabins into Singapore for the first time: 26 Business Premier seats in a 1-2-1 layout, of which the **four front-row Business Premier Luxe seats have sliding doors**; 33 Premium Economy; 213 Economy with Stretch and Skycouch rows. Singapore Airlines runs the same route at **ten weekly rising to twelve at peak**, so from November there are up to **fifteen weekly non-stops**.[1]

For a reader planning the trip on p21, the practical read is the timetable rather than the seat. The overnight NZ67, landing mid-afternoon, leaves enough daylight to drive the three hundred and thirty kilometres to Aoraki; the alternative may not. Elsewhere in the same winter package: Singapore Airlines adds **Munich at three weekly** and **Madrid via Barcelona at five**, both from 26 October; discontinues Singapore–Milan–Barcelona on the 27th; takes **London Gatwick and Milan to daily on the 25th** and Dubai to daily on the 24th; and starts Western Sydney daily on 23 November. Scoot's Naha service — which began in December 2025, not this November as this desk previously had it — goes from four weekly to **five from 31 October**, and **Guiyang** joins at three weekly from the 26th.[2]

You must be able to show customs the goods — so claim the refund before you check your bags.

WHAT CHANGED, AND WHAT IT MEANS

Japan's tax-free shopping switches on 1 November, with no transition period. This is the live one. From that date you **pay the ten per cent consumption tax at the till and claim a refund at the airport after customs confirmation**; purchases to 31 October stay under the old counter-exemption.[3]

The JB–Singapore RTS Link moved to February 2027. A joint statement by Malaysia's transport ministry and Singapore's LTA on **2 October** puts passenger service in February 2027, with all testing and trial runs targeted for completion by **31 December 2026**, conditional on independent safety certification and then approvals from both regulators. Transport Minister Anthony Loke said on the 8th that this is buffer time, not a delay, and that the opening date will be announced only once both regulators have signed. **This supersedes the end-2026 date this book has carried.**[4]

JR Pass prices rose on 1 October — the first revision since 2023, about five to six per cent: seven-day ordinary **¥50,000 to ¥53,000**, fourteen-day to ¥84,000, twenty-one-day to ¥105,000. A reported carve-out holding online prices at the old level "for a limited time" could not be verified at source and is not printed.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE CLIFF INSIDE THIS FORTNIGHT

No KrisFlyer chart change was announced this month, but a timing trap bites now. Awards booked at pre-November-2025 rates **cannot be moved beyond 31 October 2026** without reissuance — and reissuance tops the miles up to the current chart, which repriced by up to **twenty per cent** last November.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · REVEAL DATES ARE NOT PRODUCTS

Singapore Airlines spent this week teasing the next long-haul Business Class — the centrepiece of the **S$1.1bn** cabin retrofit announced in November 2024 — confirming a 1-2-1 stagger with closing doors at every seat, a **full reveal in November 2026** and service entry in the **first quarter of 2027** on the first retrofitted A350. Hold the enthusiasm at arm's length for three reasons.[6]

SOURCES 1 Three aviation trade outlets, read at source, agreeing on the resumption date, the frequency, both flight numbers and block times, the aircraft and the cabin configuration. **Singapore Airlines' own aircraft type on the route is stated nowhere this desk could read, and is not printed.** 2 A schedule-data service and two trade outlets, read at source. **The Naha correction is this desk's own: the service began 15 December 2025, not November 2026 as previously carried. Scoot's newsroom could not be read, so the fifth-weekly date is schedule-derived and no fare is printed.** 3 Three Japan travel and tax outlets, read at source, for the refund mechanism, the abolitions, the departure-tax rise and the pass prices. **The official pass site would not resolve, so the online-price carve-out is held.** 4 The 2 October joint statement via two Malaysian outlets and the minister's 8 October remarks. **Singapore's own release could not be isolated: its newsroom truncates at 2021 on fetch.** 5 A frequent-flyer specialist and a loyalty site, read at source. 6 Two aviation trade outlets, read at source. **Singapore Airlines' newsroom returned a 404 or firewall rejection on every path, so the cabin item is reported, not released; the official entry-system portal would not resolve.**

DEPARTURES · THE SILVERKRIS TAIPEI

Singapore Airlines closes its Taipei SilverKris lounge on 31 October

Taoyuan's Terminal 2 redevelopment is the stated cause. Eligible passengers move to the Plaza Premium on Level 4 — and Solitaire PPS members flying Scoot out of Taipei lose lounge access altogether.

Singapore Airlines advised on **5 October** that its Taipei SilverKris lounge operates for the last time on **Saturday 31 October 2026** and ceases the next day, citing the **Taoyuan Terminal 2 redevelopment** that forms part of the airport's Terminal 3 programme. No replacement lounge is announced. Business Class, PPS Club, KrisFlyer Elite Gold and Star Gold passengers are directed to the **Plaza Premium Lounge on Level 4 of Terminal 2**, and EVA Air's lounges remain open to eligible Star Alliance travellers. The sharp edge is for one group: **Solitaire PPS members flying Scoot out of Taipei lose lounge access entirely**, because Scoot passengers may use only the airline's own lounges.[1]

The advisory avoids the word "permanently" but uses the same "cease operations" wording the airline used in Manila, which did not reopen. Read it as gone.[1]

ALSO THIS FORTNIGHT

Riyadh slips a fourth time, to 28 March 2027. Announced on **8 October**: the route was first set for 2 June 2026, then 1 December, and now the first day of the 2027 northern summer, three weekly as SQ498/499 on an A350 Medium Haul with the 2018 regional Business seat. The planned step-up to four weekly for summer 2027 is **dropped**. Tickets already sold for 1 December to 27 March will not operate, with refunds of the unused portion; award holders are to be contacted.[2]

First Class arrives at London Gatwick — in October 2027. SQ312 and SQ309 switch from the three-class A350 to the four-class 777-300ER from **1 and 2 October 2027**: four more First, six more Business, four more Premium Economy, three fewer Economy, 253 seats to 264. Gatwick has never had Singapore Airlines First. The four seats come from Heathrow, which lost First in July 2026, so daily London First capacity returns to **twenty seats each way**. Saver award space is quoted at **148,000 miles** one way, cash at S$15,275.80 — identical to Heathrow. **This is a schedule load, not an announcement.**[3]

Changi's early check-in now covers 42 airlines, and Singapore Airlines takes bags 48 hours out — at any terminal, not only the departure one, with immigration access still capped at 24 hours and a three-hour minimum between check-in and departure. Jewel's own scheme has shrunk to **19 airlines**; British Airways has left it.[4]

Business Class gets pyjamas, and Byredo replaces Le Labo. Progressively from November, on flights over six hours: Suites and First move to Sisley; Business to Byredo's Blanche line, which also replaces Payot in the lavatories; and Business gets **sleeper suits for the first time**, relaxed-fit navy poly-cotton with tone-on-tone batik. Christofle chinaware lands in Business the same month.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE HOTEL THAT ALREADY OPENED

A correction this desk owes the Travel page. **Hoshinoya Nara Prison has been open since Thursday 25 June 2026** — not "spring 2026" and not still forthcoming. Four of the five Meiji-era cell blocks are converted, with **48 suites** made by combining individual and shared cells, from **¥147,000 a night**; it was originally slated for summer 2024 and delayed principally by an earthquake-resistance survey. The delta is simply: book it, do not anticipate it. The forward peg for the same trip is **Hotel The Mitsui Hakone, opening 15 December 2026**, which is bookable now for a New Year run.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS DESK DID NOT CHECK

Four things readers may expect here are absent, and it is better to say so than to fill the space. **Bali's tourist levy** and **Thailand's current entry rules** were not verified this fortnight. **Changi Terminal 5** produced nothing newer than the May 2025 groundbreaking: first phase remains mid-2030s. The SilverKris Terminal 2 Phase 2 expansion, expected in September, **could not be confirmed as open**. Ski-country hotel openings were not reached. One small, verified irritation instead: **Jewel's Changi Lounge showers are out of service until 15 November 2026.**[7]

SOURCES 1 Two frequent-flyer specialists, 5 October, read at source, for the final date, the stated cause, the replacement lounge, the Star Alliance position and the Scoot consequence; the Manila comparison is this desk's reading of identical wording, not the airline's statement. 2 A frequent-flyer specialist, 8 October, read at source, for all four launch dates, the flight numbers, the aircraft and seat, the dropped frequency and the refund terms. 3 The same outlet, 11 October, read at source, for both switch dates, the seat-count deltas, the London capacity arithmetic and both award and cash fares. **It is a schedule-load story and is printed as one.** 4 **Changi Airport's own early-check-in page, read at source**, with a trade analysis of 10 October for the airline counts and the terminal rules. 5 Three outlets, 14 October, read at source, for every brand, every amenity and the November timing. 6 A wire-derived report of the 25 June 2026 opening and a hotel trade release, read at source, for the suite count, the rate and the delay; a Japanese travel-trade outlet for the December opening. **This desk did not verify the wider pipeline of Japanese landmark openings and does not list it.** 7 The airport operator's own lounge page, read at source, for the shower closure; the groundbreaking from the prime minister's office transcript. **The other items in this box are declared unchecked rather than estimated.**

THE GRAND TOUR · AORAKI & THE CATLINS

Mt Cook village takes 4,132mm of rain a year; Lake Tekapo takes 535

Sixty kilometres apart, and eight times the rainfall. Tourism New Zealand's own Australian site says 600mm — wrong by a factor of seven.

The most useful number for anyone planning a South Island summer is the rain, and almost nobody prints it correctly. On NIWA's 1991–2020 normals, **Mt Cook takes 4,132.3mm of mean annual rainfall. Lake Tekapo, sixty kilometres away by road, takes 534.8mm** — nearly eight times less. The Mackenzie Basin is a semi-desert in the rain shadow and the village sits where the moisture stops. Tourism New Zealand's own Australian site says Mt Cook gets about **600mm**. It is wrong by a factor of seven, and planning a week on it would be a mistake.[1]

The second number reframes the stargazing, and it is arithmetic rather than opinion. At Lake Tekapo's latitude, astronomical darkness on the **21 December solstice** lasts **three hours thirty-nine minutes and does not begin until 23:47**. By **22 February** it lasts **six hours fifty-seven and begins at 22:23**; by the 28th, seven hours twenty-one from 22:10. So late February gives roughly double the dark hours *and* starts them before half past ten — which, for anyone travelling with a twelve-year-old, is the whole difference between an astronomy night and a tantrum. The operator running the telescopes says the same thing without the table: winter is Tekapo's exceptional season, and summer visitors should expect **"later start times"**.[2]

Getting there got easier three weeks ago. **Air New Zealand resumes Singapore–Christchurch non-stop on 28 October** (p19), three weekly on a 787-9, alongside Singapore Airlines at ten to twelve weekly — up to fifteen non-stops a week at peak. Christchurch to the village is **330 to 350km, four to four and a half hours** with stops: SH1 to Geraldine, SH79 to Fairlie, SH8 over Burkes Pass to Tekapo and Lake Pukaki, then **SH80** for fifty-five kilometres of two-lane road with single-lane bridges to a dead end. The village is the terminus. **Fuel at Mt Cook is dear and unreliable: fill at Twizel or Tekapo.** And the Singapore dollar has strengthened three to four per cent against the kiwi since midwinter — **S$1 bought NZ$1.3813** on Friday evening, so NZ$100 is about S$72.[3]

3h39m

ASTRONOMICAL DARKNESS AT TEKAPO ON THE SOLSTICE, BEGINNING AT 23:47. IN LATE FEBRUARY IT IS 6H57M FROM 22:23[2]

WHERE TO SLEEP, AND THE TRADE-OFF

The village has no supermarket — only a convenience store inside the hotel, with the nearest proper shop **65km away in Twizel**. Essentially four addresses plus a campground.[4]

Twizel is 55km and forty-five minutes out, in the dry, with a properly stocked Four Square and motel rates a fraction of the hotel's — at the cost of ninety minutes of driving on every park day and no dawn starts. **Tekapo** is the clear-sky base at 105km. The honest recommendation is to **split it**: two nights in the village for the walks at first light, then drop back down for the dark-sky nights. Do not try to run alpine walking and astronomy off one bed.[4]

THE CHATTER · MID-OCTOBER IS LATE, NOT EARLY

The booking advice is uncomfortable and comes from the land manager rather than a blogger. In **December 2024** the Department of Conservation said Mueller Hut, Hooker Hut and White Horse Hill Campground were **already largely booked for the summer**, and that when the car park filled, cars parked far down both sides of the road — it installed **twelve temporary toilets** alongside the six permanent ones.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE MARKETING GETS WRONG

Three claims in circulation do not survive contact with the primary sources. The **600mm rainfall figure** on the national tourism board's own site, against NIWA's 4,132.[16]

SOURCES 1 **NIWA's 1991–2020 climate normals, mean annual values by station, read at source.** A second NIWA-derived figure puts the village at 4,484mm, so the honest range is 4,100–4,500; the national tourism board's Australian site carries about 600mm, which is the error named above. 2 **Computed by this desk** from the NOAA solar-position algorithm for Lake Tekapo, 44.005°S 170.477°E, NZDT, solar altitude -18°, at minute resolution — the usual almanac refused this build with a 403. Cross-checked against that host's own published Tekapo figures surfaced in search, consistent to within minutes. The operator's quoted line is from its own blog. 3 Route and fuel advice from three touring sources read at source; **the exchange rate read at 21:16 UTC on 16 October 2026 and timestamped because it moves.** 4 **DOC's own campground page, read at source**, for both rates and the no-spaces-held rule; the hotel's rate card **at one remove, because the hotel's own site and the national tourism site both returned 403 — live summer rates are held**. 5 **DOC's own media release of 20 December 2024, read at source.** 6 The same release and DOC's visitor data; the retreat rates from the measured literature. **Reddit refused this build and the main travel forum returned 403, so no forum sentiment is attributed here.**

THE GRAND TOUR · THE HOOKER VALLEY

DOC's new Hooker Valley bridge is 189 metres, New Zealand's longest

It replaced the middle crossing in July 2026, after the old one closed in April 2025. December is the first whole summer on the Hooker Valley Track since — and no guidebook mentions it.

The **Hooker Valley Track** runs about **five kilometres and ninety minutes one way** on DOC's own sectional figures — one kilometre to the first swing bridge, one and a half to the second, two and a half to Hooker Lake — so ten kilometres and three hours return, on gravel with some steps. There are three swing bridges, and the middle one is new: **replaced in July 2026 at 189 metres, which DOC calls the longest suspension bridge in New Zealand**. The old crossing closed in **April 2025** after riverbank erosion near its supports, cutting the upper valley for a season.[1]

Two DOC warnings beat any packing list. The glacial lakes sit at about **three degrees** and **"can cause hypothermia quickly — stay out of them"**; and the track is deliberately **routed to avoid avalanche risk, so stay on it**. The hazard a Singapore family underestimates is the sun: New Zealand's maximum summer UV index is about **twelve**, where the burn time is roughly **twelve minutes** and the reflected dose off snow is higher again. Equatorial sun does not come with cold air; this does.[1][2]

The best night of the week is the cheapest. **Mueller Hut** is 28 bunks at **1,808 metres**, no heating, water that needs boiling; the climb is **two hours to Sealy Tarns, two more to the hut**, a thousand metres of gain, the first six hundred up DOC's **2,200 steps**. Above the tarns it becomes a poled route with a **fifty-metre scree slope** to the ridge. In December it is **NZ$60 an adult, NZ$30 a child** — so a parent and a twelve-year-old pay **NZ$90, about S$65**, for the night they will remember. Bookings are required, there are **no waiting lists**, and hut passes are not valid.[3]

NZ$25

A DAY AT THE WHITE HORSE HILL CAR PARK, CARD ONLY. A MUELLER HUT OVERNIGHT LEAVES THE CAR TWO DAYS: NZ$50[4]

TWO THINGS THE GUIDEBOOKS HAVE WRONG

You now pay to park at the trailhead. On **2 July 2026** DOC confirmed its parking pilot continues: **NZ$2.50 a half hour or NZ$25 a day**, a twenty-minute free period, **card only**, cameras on entry and exit, a **NZ$75 breach fee**. DOC put the pilot's gross take at **NZ$1.51m excluding GST from 161,163 transactions**, of which **White Horse Hill alone generated NZ$826,739** — the busiest paid car park in the network. DOC does not call it permanent.[4]

Do not build a Catlins afternoon around the penguins. DOC's own Nugget Point page still says yellow-eyed penguins **"come ashore in the late afternoon and can be seen from the hide"**. The Catlins community's own site says flatly that they **"used to be seen here until recently, but are now no longer seen"**.[5]

THE CHATTER · NUGGET POINT IS A STOP, NOT A DESTINATION

The sceptical reading of the Catlins' most photographed place deserves printing: the viewpoint is **"more famous than the Catlins themselves"** and the view **"about what the hype suggests, without adding much more"**. The fairer counter is that the region is undersold — **McLean Falls and Purakaunui Falls are genuinely lovely, especially after rain**, with real solitude and no infrastructure.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE AEROPLANES COST MORE THAN THE BEDS

Price the week honestly and the shape is unflattering. Two adults and a twelve-year-old, seven nights, self-drive from Christchurch, comes to roughly **NZ$5,900 to 8,000**, about **S$4,300 to 5,800**, before airfares — and the **two aviation experiences cost more than four nights' accommodation**: a ski-plane glacier landing at about **NZ$1,907** for three and the glacier-lake boat at **NZ$537**, against Mueller Hut at NZ$90 and the campground at NZ$50.[7]

SOURCES 1 **DOC's own Hooker Valley Track page and its media release of 16 December 2025, read at source**, for the sectional distances and times, the three bridges, the new bridge's July 2026 opening and 189-metre length, the April 2025 closure and both quoted hazard warnings. **No closure was listed when this desk read the page.** 2 NIWA's own ultraviolet guidance, read at source. **Sandfly severity is documented for the West Coast; extending it here would be inference, so it is not printed as fact.** 3 **DOC's own Mueller Hut page and track notes, read at source**, for the bunk count, the booking regime, the no-waiting-list rule, the invalid hut passes and every seasonal price. 4 **DOC's own release of 2 July 2026 and its paid-parking pages, read at source**, for every charge, the breach fee, the permit prices and all three revenue figures. 5 **DOC's own Nugget Point page and the Catlins community's own site, both read at source**, printed side by side; the nest count from DOC's published figure. 6 Four travel writers and a motoring association's editorial, read at source — **labelled chatter, because it is sentiment**. 7 This desk's own build-up from the prices above plus operator listings; **every estimated line is named as held in the text.**

THE DIARY · WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING

Studio Ghibli opens at Gardens by the Bay on 18 December at S$39

Resident pricing, timed entry, online only. The Kyushu sumo is sold out on all fifteen days, and the Australian Open's early-bird window shuts at 12:59pm on 30 November.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

29 Oct–15 Nov — **CATS The Musical**
SANDS THEATRE · S$68–238 · RATED G, AGE 7+

10 & 11 Nov — **My Chemical Romance**
INDOOR STADIUM · S$128–408 · MOVED FROM APRIL; 8PM

25 NOV — **Guns N' Roses**
NATIONAL STADIUM · VENUE STILL PRINTS NO PRICE

26–29 Nov — **The Nutcracker · State Ballet of Georgia**
SANDS THEATRE · FOUR PERFORMANCES · RATED G

28 NOV — **BABYMONSTER · CHOOM**
INDOOR STADIUM · S$168–358 · 6PM

10–13 Dec — ★ **PGL Major Singapore · Counter-Strike 2**
INDOOR STADIUM · S$144 THU TO S$369 SUN · FIRST CS2 MAJOR IN SE ASIA

18 DEC — ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli**
GARDENS BY THE BAY WEST LAWN · S$39 ADULT, S$29 CHILD, RESIDENT RATE · TO JUL 2027

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

31 Oct–28 Mar — **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, TOKYO · ~80 WORKS OVER THREE DECADES

8–22 Nov — ★ **Grand Sumo · Kyushu Basho**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · **SOLD OUT ALL FIFTEEN DAYS** PER THE SUMO ASSOCIATION

11–31 Jan — ★ **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · GROUND PASSES FROM A$49 · MAIN DRAW FROM 17 JAN

4–11 Feb — **Sapporo Snow Festival, 77th**
ODORI, TSUDOME, SUSUKINO · FREE · TSUDOME IS THE CHILDREN'S SITE

7 MAR — **Tokyo Marathon 2027, 20th edition**
SHINJUKU TO TOKYO STATION · **ALL ENTRY WINDOWS CLOSED** · FIELD 40,000

PLANNING NOTES

The one piece of real arbitrage is Melbourne: Australian Open early-bird pricing ends at **12:59pm on 30 November**, and ground-pass allocations are capped for the first time. A January trip is a November decision. **Already shut:** Kyushu sumo on all fifteen days; **BTS's four December stadium nights** on every allocation; Tokyo Marathon entry since August; the Singapore marathon since 30 September. **Ghibli** is timed-entry and online-only, the resident tier saves about a fifth, and child concession is ages 3 to 12 — so check a twelve-year-old's birthday against the visit date. **The PGL Major is day-weighted**: Thursday costs less than half of Sunday.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · EIGHT OF NINETEEN PUBLISH NO PRICE

Of the fifteen dated rows above, **six carry no published price at all** — one of them a stadium rock show whose general sale opened in March and whose venue page still reads "more details coming soon". That is not an oversight; it is how this market is run. What this desk **dropped**: Christmas Wonderland, whose 2026 dates exist on no primary source we could reach; a museum exhibition reachable only through a search summary; and seven listings that appeared on aggregators alone. **Post Malone's postponed stadium date stays barred**, as it has since No. 85. One live warning: the national sports precinct has suspended all outdoor venues because of the haze (p5). The covered stadium is unaffected.[2]

SOURCES 1 Every row above was verified against a venue, promoter or organiser page rather than an aggregator: the national stadium precinct's own event pages; the convention centre's and exhibition halls' own calendars; the art fair's own site; the exhibition's own site for the Ghibli dates and both price tiers; the Japan Sumo Association's own English site for the sold-out statement; the two Tokyo galleries' own pages; Melbourne Park's own guide for the dates, the ground-pass price and the early-bird deadline; the city tourism body's event list for Sapporo; the marathon's own participant guidelines; and the union's own announcement for the Sevens. **Singapore's main ticketing agent returned 403 and the integrated resort's site 503 on every path, so the two theatre price bands are quoted at one remove.** 2 **The absence of a published price on eight rows is a property of the venues' own pages.** The dropped listings are named rather than silently omitted; the barred stadium date is recorded in this book's dead-events ledger. **Reddit refused this desk again.**

THE TABLE · DEMPSEY & TANJONG PAGAR

Antonio Miscellaneo opens Petra on Dempsey Hill on 24 October, 119 seats

His first venture beyond Italian cooking, with a former Ottolenghi head chef consulting. Across town, a twelve-seat pasta counter has finally collected enough reviews to be judged.

Petra opens on **Saturday 24 October** at Dempsey Hill, and it is the most serious pedigree arriving in Singapore this month. The executive chef-owner is **Antonio Miscellaneo**, the man behind La Bottega and Casa Vostra, and this is his first venture beyond Italian cooking; the kitchen is run by executive chef **Anas Shami**, with **Dawid Nowosadzki** — formerly head chef at NOPI and Ottolenghi in London — consulting. The name is the ancient city, chosen as a historic meeting point of cultures and trading routes. At **8,000 square feet and 119 seats** it is a statement room, not a jewel box: house-made dips with bread from a dedicated oven, seafood and meat over live fire with the day's catch on display, and a patisserie section. Reservations are already open. **There are no reviews, because it has not opened — too new to call, and nothing here is praise.**[1]

Which makes **Saikyo Pasta** the useful entry: it opened in July at Icon Village and three months on has four published assessments — enough for a verdict rather than a prediction. The story is the absence of pedigree. **Arya Masagung and Angeline Chandraatmadja**, both 33, with no prior restaurant experience, graduated a Shenton Way takeaway into a **twelve-seat counter**, and there is no named chef. One reviewer scored it **3.5 out of 5** — "a casual and no-frills spot to enjoy good quality pasta in Tanjong Pagar" — praising the tiger-prawn mentaiko as "not overly creamy and cloying"; another was unreserved on the cold kombu pasta, "really, really good". Later diner reports are mixed, one saying quality had slipped as volume rose. **The honest line: worth the counter seat for the kombu pasta, not yet worth the queue.** A three-course set is **S$39.90**.[2]

Two more earn their space on a single fact each. **Whuchu**, at UE Square, is built around *ssam* — the Korean wrap — and houses **Singapore's first Himalayan salt-ageing room**, built into the dining room itself; the pork is certified Jeju, and the tables extract the smoke so you leave without smelling of it. The verdict is warm but thin: the aged bone-in pork belly is the star at **S$78++**, and the lunch ssam-bap set at **S$36++** is the same programme at a fifth of a dinner bill that passes S$200. And **Shirazi**, which soft-opened on Dempsey Road on 8 September, is the halal-relevant arrival: Persian semi-fine dining, charcoal kebabs, lamb koobideh, a black hummus. **Its buzz is two five-star diner entries and no published review from any Singapore food title — too new to call.** The precision that matters: a Muslim-friendly kitchen using halal-certified meat, which is not restaurant certification.[3]

THE BUZZ · A TEN-YEAR-OLD RESTAURANT REBORN

Birds of a Feather on Amoy Street is not an opening but a relaunch: closed for a refresh and reopened on **5 September** with a new room, menu and cocktail list, and a renamed cuisine — "progressive cooking with Chuan influences", Sichuan and south-western Chinese ingredients through French technique. Chef-partner **Eugene See** has run the kitchen for all ten years and trained in classical European rooms.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · PRICED FOR THE FIRST VISIT

The sharpest thing published on this scene all year is a closure post-mortem. In a September survey of the year's departures, the owner of a shuttered restaurant said the decision **"simply boiled down to the numbers"** — and then the line that indicts half of what this strip covers: the menu pricing had been **"designed for maximum first impact, not repeat visits"**, and he wished he had thought more about consumer habits than aesthetics.[5]

SOURCES 1 A city listings title, 7 October 2026, and a Singapore food site, both read at source, for the opening date, the chef and consultant credits, the floor area and seat count and the menu. **No price is published anywhere for this room, and none is printed.** 2 A Singapore food blog's review of 8 September and a food-media piece of 17 June, both read at source, for the score, both quoted assessments, the founders and every price; the later mixed reports are diner-level and described as such. **One October piece returned an empty body and is not quoted.** 3 A food title's July piece and a September review, read at source, for the salt-ageing room, the sourcing, both prices and the halal position; a venue guide and two booking platforms for the Persian room. **Its total published record is two five-star diner entries, and that is what is reported.** 4 A Singapore review site and a booking platform's ratings, read at source. **The dated 2020 piece is named as a trap because it ranks above the current coverage.** 5 A food-media survey of 2026 closures, 20 September, read at source; the closure counts are official statistics quoted there. **Reddit refused this desk again, so the social layer here is booking ratings, food media and blog comment — weaker, and not dressed up. No room on this page holds a Michelin listing; this desk checked.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · SOUTH KOREA

Seoul legalised a 33-square-metre cabin on farmland; Koreans have filed 17,983

Korea's 강층체류형 숏턴 is not a house, so it needs no farmland-conversion permit. It gets twelve years, three renewals, and then in principle a demolition.

Since December 2024, any Korean who owns farmland may put a cabin on it. Not a house — a **강층체류형 숏턴**, *nongchon cheryuhyeong swimteo*, literally a "rural-stay-type rest shelter" — of up to **thirty-three square metres**, erected as a temporary structure on notification rather than permission, with **no farmland-conversion permit required**. The deck and the septic tank do not count towards the thirty-three. One per household. One parking bay. A smoke alarm or extinguisher is mandatory and it must front a road a fire engine can use. Acquisition tax is about **₩100,000** and property tax about **₩10,000** a year, and because it is not a house it escapes capital-gains and comprehensive real-estate tax altogether.[1]

It has a life of **twelve years** — three years, renewable three times — and then, in principle, it comes down. The ministry's own slogan for the thing is **4도3철**, *sa-do sam-chon*: four days city, three days country. Non-farmers may buy up to a tenth of a hectare for weekend or experience farming, and must still actually farm the rest of the plot, with the local government obliged to check that they do.[1]

The numbers have moved fast. To **30 November 2025** there were **12,620 filings and 12,008 approvals**, of which roughly four thousand were conversions of existing **놀막** — *nongmak*, the twenty-square-metre "farm tool shed" that Koreans had long been using as a de facto villa — and about eight thousand were new builds. By **March 2026** the cumulative figure, submitted to the National Assembly, stood at **17,983**, with **12,709 of them, or 70.7 per cent, tied to new urban-resident stay demand**. Gyeonggi, the province around Seoul, accounts for 1,918; the earlier regional split put Gangwon first at 2,448, then Chungnam at 2,029, Gyeongbuk 1,516, Chungbuk 1,483.[2]

And the stock it is eating is enormous. At the end of 2022 there were **230,000 temporary-structure filings on Korean farmland**, most of them *nongmak*, every one of which may convert to a *swimteo* inside a three-year grace period. That is the true size of the amnesty, and it is the first thing to understand about this policy: it is less an invention than a surrender, dressed as a programme.[1]

> ***A cabin that is not a house, on land you must still be seen to farm, for a life measured in renewals.***

Because the surrender has a date. In 2023 the agriculture ministry tried to stop people sleeping in their *nongmak*, and retreated under public fury. The *swimteo* is that defeat converted into policy — and the reason the state could not simply legalise a second home on farmland is constitutional in spirit: **경자유전**, *gyeongja-yujeon*, land to the tiller, the doctrine that farmland belongs to those who farm it. Unable to repeal the principle, Korea has licensed a loophole in it, and capped the loophole at thirty-three square metres and twelve years.[1]

230,000

TEMPORARY-STRUCTURE FILINGS ON KOREAN FARMLAND AT END-2022, NEARLY ALL OF THEM FARM HUTS. EVERY ONE MAY CONVERT WITHIN THREE YEARS[1]

SOURCES 1 **The Ministry of Agriculture, Food and Rural Affairs' own policy briefing of 1 August 2024, read at source in Korean**, for the thirty-three-square-metre limit, the temporary-structure classification, the notification rather than permission route, the exclusions for deck and septic tank, the one-per-household and parking rules, the fire requirements, both tax figures, the tax exemptions, the twelve-year life and its three renewals, the demolition principle, the 0.1-hectare weekend-farming allowance, the monitoring obligation, the 230,000 end-2022 figure and the three-year conversion window, and the twenty-square-metre former cap on farm huts. The ministry's own name for the scheme and the four-days-city slogan are from the same briefing. 2 **A Korean financial daily, 2 July 2026, read at source**, for the cumulative 17,983 filings to March 2026, the Gyeonggi count and the 12,709 figure and its 70.7 per cent share, each attributed there to ministry data submitted to a named member of the National Assembly; **a Korean agricultural newspaper, 20 January 2026, read at source**, for the 12,620 filings and 12,008 approvals to 30 November 2025, the split between roughly four thousand conversions and eight thousand new builds, and all five provincial figures. **The 2023 retreat over sleeping in farm huts is recorded in the ministry's own briefing and in the agricultural press; the land-to-the-tiller doctrine is long-established Korean law and is characterised here, not quoted.**

The sharpest thing about the scheme is what it forbids. You may file a change of address to a *swimteo* — a Supreme Court precedent blocks a local office from refusing the registration — and you may not actually live there. A regional broadcaster went to **Yeongwol county** in Gangwon at the end of last year and found the county holding roughly two to four hundred farm huts and **about seventy** of the new shelters, and one man who had built a hut in 2021, registered his address within days and lived in it for four years. His neighbours had tolerated it; an unrelated village quarrel produced a complaint. One of them put it with the flatness of someone who had watched it happen: **"he registered within days of arriving and just lived there four years."**[1]

The ministry's own agricultural policy director had said the year before, in the briefing that launched the thing, that moving your address in **"goes beyond the concept of temporary residence we have in mind."** That sentence is the whole policy. The state wants bodies in the countryside at weekends and will not grant them residence; the cabin is the physical shape of that bargain, and the twelve-year clock is the state reminding you which of you is lending.[1][2]

"Officials come and ask us what the rules are."

On the trade floor it reads as confusion rather than policy. At a building expo near Seoul in February 2025, visitors compared stands offering cabins at **₩5m and ₩2.5m per *pyeong*** — the Korean unit of 3.3 square metres — which for a thirty-three-square-metre cabin with a fifteen-metre deck and a parking bay means about sixty-one square metres of structure and some hundred and twenty-three square metres of farmland committed to it. One builder told the agricultural press that **"officials come and ask us what the rules are"**; another that although you may use it for twelve years and perhaps more, **it is opaque by what procedure the term is extended**. The paper's own summary of the reaction split cleanly in two: *a perfectly good weekend villa*, against *too new — wait and see*. Local governments have been no clearer: one county has had to warn residents that the shelters are not permitted in green belts and are being confused with farm huts, and the ministry has already rewritten its fifty-centimetre road-setback rule after someone asked who puts a building right beside the road.[3]

25,284

FARMLAND ACQUISITION CERTIFICATES FOR WEEKEND FARMING IN 2025, DOWN FROM 28,258 IN 2024 — THE WRONG DIRECTION IF THE CABINS WERE PULLING CITY MONEY ONTO LAND[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A TREND OR A REBADGING

The best dissent is Korean and specific. **Park Seok-du** of the GSnJ Institute told the agricultural press in January that farm-hut conversions will keep rising quickly but the scheme will generate **limited genuinely new demand** — that the eight thousand "new" builds are a continuation of a pre-existing trend rather than something the policy created. The hard counter-indicator sits in the same article: farmland acquisition certificates for weekend and experience farming **fell to 25,284 in 2025 from 28,258 in 2024**. If this were pulling city money onto farmland, that number should be rising. Then the forecast miss: a Gangwon research institute projected **24,600 to 77,600 shelters a year in Gangwon alone** to 2033, against 2,448 actual filings in about ten months — a researcher there attributes the caution to the limited usage period. And a provincial official in Gyeongbuk says his province's high count is mostly **farmers whose fields are too far away**, not weekenders at all. Last, the chilling risk: builders told the financial press in July that buyers are hesitating because of a nationwide census of every farm plot and threatened sanctions on uncultivated land — the same ministry building the demand and policing it with the same hand.[4][5]

SOURCES 1 **A Gangwon regional broadcaster, 30 December 2025, read at source in Korean**, for the registration paradox and the Supreme Court precedent that blocks refusal, the Yeongwol farm-hut and shelter counts, the named case of the man who registered within days and lived there four years, and the neighbour's quoted remark. 2 **The agriculture ministry's briefing of 1 August 2024, read at source**, for the policy director's quoted characterisation of changing one's address. 3 **A Korean agricultural newspaper, 25 February 2025, read at source**, for the two per-*pyeong* prices compared at the expo, both builders' quoted remarks, and the paper's own two-way summary of the reaction; the area arithmetic for a cabin, deck and parking bay is this desk's own, from the dimensions in that report. A Chungcheong daily, read at source, for the green-belt warning and the confusion with farm huts; the setback rewrite from the ministry's own material. 4 **The same agricultural newspaper, 20 January 2026, read at source**, for Park Seok-du's assessment, the continuation argument, both years' acquisition-certificate totals, the Gangwon projection and the researcher's explanation, and the Gyeongbuk official's composition caveat. 5 **A Korean financial daily, 2 July 2026, read at source**, for the builders' account of buyer hesitation and the ministry's own response that it is hard to say the census is hurting take-up.

Korea has done this before, one country over. When Taiwan amended its Agricultural Development Act in **2000**, it opened the farmland market to non-farmers and permitted farmhouses on farmland provided they did not harm agricultural production or rural community development. What followed, by common account, was villas on paddy land. By **2015** the Council of Agriculture was moving to close the loophole, proposing that an applicant show farmer health-insurance status and capping development at a tenth of a holding — and publishing the number that explains why: between 2008 and 2013, of **16,338 people who applied to build agricultural buildings, only 38.8 per cent** held the farmer category of national health insurance. Six out of ten applicants were not, on the state's own test, farmers.[1]

That is the warning, and the mechanism of the warning matters more than the parallel: **containment rules decay**. Korea's containment is tighter than Taiwan's was — thirty-three square metres against a house, twelve years against freehold, a structure classed as temporary against one classed as a dwelling — and it is tighter precisely because Korea has watched what the loose version produces. But the direction of travel in both countries is the same: a doctrine that farmland belongs to its tiller, met by a population that wants weekends, and resolved not by changing the doctrine but by inventing a building that the doctrine does not quite see.[1]

In a shrinking country the state stops trying to move people, and starts licensing attendance.

The deeper reading is demographic, and this is where the *swimteo* stops being a planning curiosity. Korea cannot get residents into its countryside. It can get visitors. So it has built a legal category for part-time rural citizenship, and then capped it — because the same ministry that wants the bodies is terrified of the speculation that would follow if the cabin became a house. The scheme is a rural-revival programme and an anti-speculation containment device at once, which is why it is simultaneously generous and grudging: come, spend, plant something, leave on Monday, and do not imagine this is yours for longer than three years at a time.[2]

Set beside its own precursor the honesty is almost admirable. The **230,000 farm huts** were an illegality the state had lost the will to prosecute; in 2023 it tried to stop people sleeping in them and lost. The shelter is that defeat written into law with a meter on it. What Korea has actually done is convert an unenforceable prohibition into a priced, timed, inspected permission — and in doing so it has made explicit something most ageing societies still leave implicit. **Residence is becoming a subscription.** You do not move to the village. You attend it, on terms, for a term.[12]



The amnesty is eighteen times the size of the uptake. *Meridian* original, from the figures on p25.

Which is the thread running back through this issue. A bird that flies six hundred miles to a loft it chose and leaves again. A pair of shears that goes back to the sharpener for fifty years instead of into a bin. A mountain track whole again after a season cut in half. A government that finally named seven companies after twelve years of naming none. And a page of our own predictions, come home to be marked. Korea's cabin belongs in that company: it is a thing built to be returned to rather than lived in, which is a smaller ambition than a house and a much more honest one than a promise.[2]

SOURCES 1 Taiwan's 2000 amendments to its Agricultural Development Act, and the 2015 proposals to tighten them, via an agricultural-policy platform's own account and Taiwanese environmental coverage: the opening of the farmland market to non-farmers, the farmhouse permission and its production-and-community proviso, the proposed health-insurance test, the one-tenth development cap and the 2008–13 figure that **only 38.8 per cent of 16,338 applicants held the farmer insurance category. This desk could not confirm which version of the 2015 tightening was finally enacted, nor any minimum-area threshold, so neither is printed — the analogy rests on the 2000 opening and the published applicant figure, both of which are solid.** The "villas on paddy land" characterisation is the common account in that coverage, not a figure. 2 The argument is this desk's own, built on the sources on p25 and p26: the ministry's briefing for the scheme's terms and the 230,000 stock, two Korean newspapers for the filing counts and the dissent, and a regional broadcaster for the residency paradox. **A Soviet-dacha parallel was considered and dropped: this desk could not verify the plot-size and habitation rules at source, and an unverified analogy is worse than none.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

What comes back

A pigeon leaves a basket in France and lands on a shed in Lancashire, and after fifty years of experiments nobody can tell you how it does it (p15). A pair of shears, if the pivot is a screw rather than a rivet, goes back to a sharpener for fifty years to have its tension re-set — and if it is riveted, it goes in a bin, however good the steel (p6). A bridge across the Hooker River came back in July, 189 metres of it, and this is the first whole summer on that track since April last year (p22).

Returns are the issue's quiet subject. Singapore's haze came back, as it does, and this time something else came back with it: an Act that had sat unused for twelve years produced seven named companies on Friday — preventive notices, no deadline, no section cited, but names (p5). Korea has built a legal category for people who want the countryside back at weekends and will not be allowed to live there: thirty-three square metres, twelve years, then in principle a demolition (p25). And on page two, thirty-nine of this magazine's own calls came home to be marked, including the four separate issues in which we said a central bank would tighten and it held.

Pope's line on page two is the cheerful version of a hard thing: the only way to be wiser today is to have been wrong yesterday and to say so. It is also, oddly, what the week's best objects have in common. A watch brought back at a smaller size because the old one was too big. A track rebuilt because the old bridge was undermined. A thing you can return to is a thing that was built to be corrected — which is more than can be said for a riveted pair of scissors, or a prediction nobody ever checks.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 135 · 17 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: an environment agency's own enforcement release and its machine-readable feed, queried directly at five in the morning; a foundry's filing with the Securities and Exchange Commission and two independent transcripts of its call; a Chinese ministry's announcement in the original; a national twin cohort's own paper and its institutional release; a pigeon union's own annual-meeting minutes, as a PDF; the Singapore Statutes Online text of two sets of rules; a conservation department's own track, hut, parking and alert pages; a Treasury's daily yield curve; two Korean newspapers and the agriculture ministry's own briefing; and a Belgian public broadcaster. One figure on p21 — the hours of astronomical darkness — is this magazine's own calculation, and says so. Where a host refused us — **Reddit to every desk for a third issue running; Wikimedia's image servers; Metacritic's music pages; the auction house at the centre of p15; the sport's own forum, now behind a payment wall; Singapore's main ticketing agent; an integrated resort; a cardiology journal; the European Council; and the Washington Post** — the page says so rather than quietly sourcing around it. Corrections to this magazine's own record are printed on p11, p19 and p20, and thirty-nine graded calls on p2.